

INBRIEF



Over five lakh children in city given polio vaccine

The Greater Chennai Corporation on Sunday vaccinated 5,06,426 children, achieving 91% coverage under the Intensified Pulse Polio Immunisation Drive across zones. The remaining 50,451 children, who could not be vaccinated on Sunday, will be covered during the upcoming mop-up rounds, according to officials.

Policeman dies after being knocked down by truck

Jaiganesh, a 48-year-old policeman, was fatally knocked down by a sewage lorry on Rajiv Gandhi Salai on Sunday. When he was proceeding from his house on a two-wheeler, the lorry hit his vehicle from behind. Jaiganesh sustained a severe head injury and died on the spot. Police arrested the driver.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (June 29, Monday), the following articles are available:

- Can neutral ships be lawfully attacked? newsth.live/shipattacks
- Smart AI caching can keep the data flowing when disaster strikes newsth.live/aicaching

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Koyambedu market hit by waterlogging owing to delay in storm-water drain work

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

Koyambedu Market Complex was inundated on Sunday after a spell of rain in the city.

Traders and visitors complained about the inundation of the market complex on social media on Sunday.

Visitors complained that sewage was mixing with rainwater in the area, increasing the risk to the health of the visitors to the market complex.

Following the rise in number of complaints on social media, the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority (CMDA) installed motor pumps to bail out the water.

By evening, the water receded inside the market



Visitors to the Koyambedu market complex complain that sewage mixes with rainwater, posing a health risk to them. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

complex, but a few stretches of roads in the area continued to witness water stagnation.

Senior CMDA officials said the work on the storm

water drain network in the market complex was not completed because of the delay in traffic police clearance to implement the work across the highway

Senior CMDA officials said the delay in work was because of the delay in traffic police clearance to implement the work across Poonamallee High Road

stretch of Poonamallee High Road to drain the water to the nearest waterway.

The work on a new storm water drain network was announced by the DMK government in the Assembly in 2024. The work was carried out at an estimated cost of ₹17 crore. However, the delay in the work across the highway has increased the risk of flooding in the market complex.

Ex-IFMR associate pens down experiences in book

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

T.S. Gopal, who was long associated with the Institute for Financial Management and Research (IFMR), has penned a book 'Walk With Me Down Memory Lane' in which he recalls his experiences in professional and public life and his passion for music.

Retired High Court judge Justice Prabha Sridevan released the book and former Chief Election Commissioner T.S. Krishnamurthy received the first copy at TAG Centre in the city on Sunday.

After releasing the book, Justice Prabha Sridevan said that it was an engaging and engrossing book and one could come across several genres of writing in the book laced with humour.

The book showed that Mr. Gopal has gone beyond the call of duty during his service at IFMR, Ms. Sride-



Dignitaries at the launch of author T.S. Gopal's book 'Walk With Me Down Memory Lane' in Chennai on Sunday. R. RAGU

van said. As someone who kept engaging with students, Mr. Gopal has remained young and music too has played a role. "Even while intending to help someone socially, he has some very special guidelines. He thinks events organised by institutions that help people must be simple," Justice Prabha Sridevan said.

Mr. Gopal thought organisations which subsist on largesse must not splurge, Ms. Sridevan said and added: "There is some truth there and I liked it." She further said: "As somebody who has been in the legal field, his [Mr. Gopal's] attachment to [late eminent jurist] Mr. Nani Palkhivala is something that makes him very spe-

cial to me," she said. During his speech, Mr. Krishnamurthy said Mr. Gopal had a many-sided personality with multi-talented capabilities. Endorsing Ms. Sridevan's words, Mr. Krishnamurthy said that Mr. Gopal's services went beyond his call of duty. Mr. Gopal was a fundraiser for many charitable causes and a great music

promoter, he said. "His [Mr. Gopal] experiences in the IFMR were quite exciting, in the sense, how he dealt with his bosses, starting with Mr. S.L.N. Simha and ending with Mr. Ramchander. He knew the strengths and weaknesses of the people, and he could manage inside institutional politics," Mr. Krishnamurthy said.

The book was interesting, enticing and enjoyable and was exciting all through and very well-articulated, he said.

In his speech, Mr. Gopal said as a student of English literature, he used to read judgments for their literary content.

"Many times, judges have inspired me with their language," Mr. Gopal further said: "The book is a compilation of my writings and my experiences in professional and public life." Programme organisers R.T. Chari and S.R. Madhu also spoke.

High bitumen rates press the pause on road laying works

Contractors are unable to complete the works as bitumen prices have increased since the war in West Asia; the State government is expected to take a decision on fixing the rates in the budget

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Work to re-lay damaged roads in and around the city has been disrupted owing to an increase in bitumen prices in the past few months. The prices of bitumen variants, the major component in road laying, have increased due to the war in West Asia as the cost of crude also went up. Bitumen is a byproduct of crude.

Civic agencies such as the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) have also cancelled tenders as contractors have been reluctant to implement the works owing to price escalation. Road works worth ₹60 crore have been cancelled.

The price of bitumen VG (viscosity grade) 30, which is used for smaller streets without heavy traffic, has increased from ₹47,852 per tonne in December 2025 to ₹76,852 per tonne in June 2026. Bitumen VG 40, the variant used for bus routes and highways with heavy traffic, has gone up from ₹50,342 per tonne in December 2025 to ₹84,772 per tonne in June 2026.



High costs: Contractors have not been able to complete the work after milling roads in several areas of the city. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The light diesel oil, used for heating in the plants, has soared from ₹59,464 per kilo litre to ₹1,00,444 per kilo litre.

Sources said that GCC contractors have not been able to complete the work after milling 26 roads in areas such as Sholinganalur and Ramapuram, putting motorists to hardship.

"When the road is not relaid soon after milling, road users, especially two-wheeler riders, find it difficult to use these stretches. Accidents also happen due to the road surface. The government should allow contractors to finish works that are stuck for want of bitumen," said Sholinganalur resident B. Narayanan.

Though the GCC has ordered the contractors to complete the works that have been started, contractors say they would go bankrupt if they do so. Work on 140 roads that need relaying after milling too has been delayed. GCC officials are keeping their fingers crossed hoping for some good news on July 1 when the State government is expected to take a decision on the rates.

Highways department officials also said that contractors have slowed down re-laying and repair works. "Luckily, there were no heavy rains requiring bitumen. The prices have more than doubled, which is extraordinary," said a Highways contractor.

Price adjustment clauses in contracts will be valid only if the duration of the work is for over 12 months. A feature called pass through is used for three materials-bitumen, steel and cement-for which the price bands are fixed during bidding. Agencies like NHAI and CPWD bear the additional costs if there is an extraordinary increase in prices, said a long-time Central government contractor.

This time, for NHAI projects, the Centre issued a circular stating that, after April, for ongoing projects, the difference in price of bitumen will be borne by them. However, even then, contractors found it difficult to procure bitumen since they had to pay upfront. "Earlier, they would lift the loads and then make payments. We didn't want the projects to slow down or stop as it is very difficult to restart big projects, considering the investments in men and machinery," said an official NHAI source.

Contractors and government agencies are now pegging their hopes on reduction of bitumen prices as crude rates have come back to pre-war levels.



Daily ordeal: Tipplers outside a house opposite a Tasmac outlet on Canal Bank Road in Adyar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Women, elderly bear the brunt of nuisance near Tasmac outlet in Kasturba Nagar

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

"Guests to our apartment are threatened by drunk men", said Sekar, a resident living opposite a Tasmac outlet on Canal Bank Road in Kasturba Nagar of Adyar Zone. "Women are scared to walk past. We have even helped a woman who cried out for help when a tippler allegedly tried to harass her," he said.

According to locals, a 70-year-old woman living on this street rarely ventures out alone because of fears of theft and intimidation. Neighbours and members of the Adyar Kasturba Nagar-South Residents' Welfare Association (AKNS RWA) often assist her with errands and daily activities, they claimed.

The association stated that the outlet is located within 50 metres of Kasturba Nagar MRTS station and within 500 metres of Madhya Kailash temple and Kalvair Church. It also claimed that railway authorities had objected to the location of the shop.

Mr. Sekar said, "Cars have been damaged and tyres punctured. Women feel unsafe because many men loiter here in an intoxicated state and are often not properly dressed," he alleged. This outlet was not

among the more than 700 Tasmac shops ordered to be closed by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay last month, but it must be closed, he added.

The association has been petitioning the State government to close the outlet, as public drinking, harassment and safety concerns have persisted in the area for many years.

Harassment

According to their petition to the Velachery MLA R. Kumar recently, women and girls face catcalling and harassment, particularly after 6 p.m., while customers frequently consume liquor on the roadside and park vehicles along Canal Bank Road. Quarrels among tipplers often spill onto public spaces, forcing many to avoid the stretch. The representation also cited littering of liquor bottles and food packets.

The association said drunk individuals were often found lying unconscious near entrance to houses, parking ramps and the MRTS station, creating persistent nuisance and safety hazard.

"Due to congestion around the shop, residents said they were often forced to take other interior roads for daily commute or to go to shops," they added.

Self-financing medical and dental colleges to collect fee only for 4.5 years, says State govt.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Selection Committee, Directorate of Medical Education and Research, has issued a notification directing all self-financing medical and dental colleges and State private university medical colleges to strictly comply with fee regulations relating to the MBBS course.

The circular reiterated the National Medical Commission's public notice, which directed all medical colleges/institutions/universities to collect MBBS course fee only for the prescribed academic duration

of 4.5 years. All these private institutions were told that they should not collect any other fee other than what is fixed by the committee.

It may be recalled that in February this year, a section of students, parents, and activists flagged an issue that some self-financing medical colleges in Tamil Nadu were demanding tuition fees for the fifth year of MBBS/BDS, which is the internship year, from Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe students despite rules prohibiting the same and directives from the Directorate of Medical Education and Research.

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INBRIEF



GCC Commissioner reviews monsoon-related measures

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has set August as the deadline to complete all ongoing storm-water drain works. Commissioner G.S. Sameeran, during a review meeting at the Ripon Buildings on Saturday, directed officials to expedite the de-silting of 44 waterways and canals, restoration of lakes, strengthening of flood-protection walls, completion of lake improvement works, and removal of blockages at river and outfall canals. According to a press release, officials were asked to prioritise connecting incomplete storm-water drain stretches and continue de-silting silt traps.

History-sheeter shot in leg and arrested near Vandalur

A history-sheeter, Selva from Oterri near Vandalur, was apprehended after being shot in the leg by police officials on Sunday. A senior police official of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said Chella alias Selvakumar had three murder and 10 criminal cases against him. Based on a tip-off, a special police team raided his hideout in Oterri. However, on seeing the team arrive, Selvakumar and his accomplice Kanakaraj allegedly assaulted an officer with a knife in a bid to escape. In retaliation, Oterri police Sub Inspector Sathesh shot the accused in his leg and nabbed him. A policeman sustained injury in the alleged knife assault. The police team seized more than 20 kg of ganja. While Selvakumar was admitted to Tambaram Government Hospital for treatment, his accomplice Kanakaraj was also arrested.

Several raise voice against new amendment act at Pride march

LGBTQIA+ community expresses disappointment with Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act 2026 with many wearing customised clothes symbolising their opposition to the Act. They also carry slogans on inclusivity, rights

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

At the 18th edition of Chennai's annual Self-Respect Pride March, some parents whose children are part of the LGBTQIA+ community came together to flag off the Pride march at Rajarathinam Stadium on Sunday. It was hosted by many organisations and volunteers that come under the Tamil Nadu Rainbow Coalition.

There were more placards, this time, about the community's disappointment with the Union Government's Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act 2026 and many even wore customised clothes signifying the same, apart from raising slogans on inclusivity and rights.

"We have asked parents who have accepted their children that are part of the community to inaugurate the march because it acknowledges them as well as encourages other parents to do the same," said Jaya, general manager at Sahodaran. Apart from the amendment act, she said the State government should look into pending demands such as horizon-



Asserting their rights: Participants at the annual Self-Respect Pride March in the city on Sunday seen sporting colourful headgears, umbrellas, and flags. Several organisations and volunteers came together to conduct the event. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



tal reservation, employment opportunities in Tamil Nadu, altering the Tamil name of the transgender welfare board to Thirunar Nala Variyam, gender-neutral washrooms, and surrogacy rights. "More sensitisation programmes should be carried out in schools by the State government," Ms. Jaya added.

Prathiba and Varadarajan who were holding a placard that read 'Proud Parent Ally' said many parents have a binary idea of the world and expect their children to fit into those ideas. "This is where the issue of acceptance comes

The Pride March included a 'Naangal' programme, where folk dance and spoken word poetry were performed

from, but acceptance is all the community is looking for," they said.

With many different identities in the community, the members who walked along held specific pride flags. A couple of 18-year-olds, Cherishma and Tejaswini who attended the Pride March for the first time said they had been waiting for this day

with so much excitement. "We raised slogans against homophobia and for inclusivity. We thought many older people will only show up but a lot of people of our age have come, which makes us happy," said Ms. Cherishma.

Apart from thousands of people who gathered at the march from Chennai, a few also joined from other parts of the world. At the entrance of the stadium, there were colourful headgears, umbrellas, flags that anyone could pick up for the march, along with about 20 outlets with volunteers who gave away refreshments. Rachel, a trans-

woman said that the Pride March is primarily about their rights. She added that the amendment act was regressive.

A young trans man who did not want to be named, said that the amendment act erases trans men completely, and many in the community have been deeply distressed by it this year.

The Pride March ended with a 'Naangal' programme, where singers, dancers, poets from the community, and allies showcased performances from folk dance to spoken word poetry. Activists also spoke at the gathering.

Hospital for geriatric care inaugurated in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, on Sunday, inaugurated Athulya Geriatric Care Hospital, dedicated to geriatric care, at Valasaravakkam in Chennai.

'Dignified care' Mr. Arlekar said geriatric care should go beyond medical infrastructure and technology, and place equal emphasis on compassion and human connection. While the neglect of older persons by younger generations was a broader societal issue, he



Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar inaugurates Athulya Geriatric Care Hospital in the city on Sunday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

said healthcare facilities catering to the elderly should be equipped with modern medical equip-

ment while ensuring that patients receive dignified, humane care. Karthik Narayan, foun-

der and managing director of Athulya Senior Care, said India's rapidly ageing population underscored the urgent need for specialised geriatric healthcare. He noted that the country has nearly 116 million senior citizens, a figure projected to rise to around 340 million by 2050.

Health infrastructure Dr. Narayan pointed out that India has only around 20,000 dedicated senior care beds, compared with nearly eight million in China and close to three million in the U.S. He said Ath-

ulya Hospital was established to bridge this gap and deliver integrated care tailored to the physical, emotional, and functional needs of older adults.

The facility was launched in the presence of G. Srinivasan, founder and CEO, Athulya Senior Care, Krishna Kavya, founder and director, and Prasanna Natarajan, director. The hospital offers comprehensive and multidisciplinary medical services across medical specialties, including cardiology, nephrology, and rehabilitation medicine.

Three men found dead after being hit by trains

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Three men were found dead on railway tracks after being hit by trains in three different places on Saturday night. While one was found dead near the track between Guindy and St. Thomas Mount, another was lying dead on the track near Chromepet station. The other man was found dead near the platform at Tiruvallur railway station.

WESTERN RAILWAY CONSTRUCTION WORKS

Deputy Chief Engineer (Construction)II, Western Railway, RATLAM (MP) invites Tender No.RTM-RNQD-DYCE-C-II-02, Name of Work: Construction of major and minor bridges, protection works & other miscellaneous works between proposed Nagda and Ratlam 3rd and 4th Line section in connection with Nagda - Ratlam Quadrupling Project of Ratlam Division - Western Railway. NIT Cost: ₹ 92.51.03.149.43. Bid Security: ₹ 1,85,02,100/- Bid Submission Closing Date: On 20.07.2026 At 15:00 Hrs. Bid Opening Date: On 20.07.2026 At 15:30 Hrs. For further details please visit our website www.irps.gov.in 0308

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Pushpanjali Cultural Trust
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Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4.
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CHANGE OF NAME

I, AMITH Kumar Sharma, s/o; Lakshmi Narayan Sharma r/o: Tower No.4, Flat No 094, DLF Garden City, Semmancherry, Sholinganallur, Kancheepuram-600119 Have changed my name as Amith Kumar Lakshmi Narayan Sharma.

I, HARSHIL Sharma Amith Kumar, s/o; Amith Kumar Lakshmi Narayan Sharma r/o: Tower No.4, Flat No 094, DLF Garden City, Semmancherry, Sholinganallur, Kancheepuram-600119 Have changed my name as Harshil Sharma

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Place : Kumbakonam
Date : 29.06.2026

For City Union Bank Limited
Company Secretary

Government of Maharashtra
Mahatma Phule Krishi Vidyapeeth, Rahuri
Office: University Engineer, MPKV, Rahuri

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Fax No. 02426-243601
e-mail: uniengineermpkv@gmail.com

Address: Central Campus, Administrative Building, Mahatma Phule Krishi Vidyapeeth, Rahuri, Tal- Rahuri, Dist- Ahmednagar, Pin-413722

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4	Construction of Boys Hostel Building at Central Campus MPKV Rahuri.	8,38,46,226.00
5	Construction of Compound wall along boundaries of Sy.No.48, 57/1,59, 60 and 62 at College of Agriculture, Pune.	4,88,93,390.00
6	Construction of Administrative Building, sale counter & Farm Structures for Agriculture Technical School and various farm & allied structures for Kuran Dairy Farm at Manjri, Dist-Pune.	10,85,45,710.00

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Parents worry over lack of clarity on three-language policy

With English considered a foreign language, Class IX and X students have been forced to change their second language at the last minute. Parents are frustrated over the policy's rushed implementation

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

Parents and teachers are frustrated with the confusion regarding the implementation of the three-language policy for Classes IX and X at CBSE schools as the deadline approaches. Practical difficulties, lack of student agency, and last-minute stress to learn a new language are just some of the challenges in implementing the circular, said educators.

While the CBSE circular stated that two of the languages opted by the students should be native to India, while the other could be a foreign lan-

guage. However, educators pointed out that English, which was the medium of instruction in most CBSE schools, was considered a foreign language, thereby ruling out the option of learning a foreign language such as French. This has been a cause for concern for Class X students set to face the boards this academic year.

Under pressure
For Aditi, a Class X student of a private CBSE school in the city, learning Tamil as the second language in time for her board exams has been stressful. She opted for French from Class VI as she wanted to pursue her higher education el-

sewhere. “She has to face her board exam, and this is unnecessary stress for her. Will she be able to focus on her core subjects to pursue the stream she wants or focus on the language to make sure she passes? We don’t know Hindi and hence, Tamil is the more logical option but at what cost?” asked Sreena N., Aditi’s mother.

In May, CBSE had directed all schools to implement three languages for Classes VI to X, where at least two of the languages taught are native languages.

While the Class X student will not have to write a board exam in the third language, the internal



Short on time: Class X students, who had to switch from French to other Indian languages, are stressed as they will have to learn the new language before they take up their board exams. R. RAGU

marks will appear on the pass certificate.

Veda, a Class IX student, has to opt for Hindi as the third language but nobody in her family knew it. “We are all stressed for her. None of us know the lan-

guage to even offer support. This is a bad decision,” said her mother Renu (name changed).

Varsha (name changed), mother of a Class IX student, added that there had been no clarity from the

school regarding the language question. “She was a French student and will now have to learn some other language but how will this progress? There has been no answer from anyone,” she said.

Shortage of teachers
School principals pointed out that practically the policy could not be implemented as the number of Indian language teachers do not match the demand.

“CBSE has taken the decision to implement the policy right before schools reopen. What of the teachers we have already hired? Further, if a couple of students want to learn Malayalam, where are the

teachers to teach them?” asked N. Vijayan, senior principal of Zion and Alwin Group of schools.

Pointing out that CBSE had approved their affiliate schools to take up English as a medium of instruction, Mr. Vijayan added that English as the foreign language should be removed so students get a choice to learn another foreign language of their choice.

With English’s status as a foreign language limiting options, many schools have been forced to rely on their already existing options and introduce Sanskrit as the third language. Hence, schools in the city have decided to wait for

the Supreme Court decision, which is scheduled for mid-July, when the court reopens after vacation.

But parents pointed out that the verdict would still cause a massive disruption as it would come in the middle of the school year.

Raghu (name changed), a parent of a Class VII student, said their child could not opt for her mother tongue Konkani, as there are neither teachers nor textbooks.

“She will be forced to take Hindi. This indirect imposition of the Hindi language due to abrupt implementation violates our fundamental rights,” he added.

Elevated corridor from Nallur to Madhavaram may happen if State waives its portion of GST for project

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

There remains a glimmer of hope for the construction of a 10.4-km elevated corridor from Madhavaram to Nallur toll plaza. Sources in the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) said the project would be revived if the State government waived its portion of the Goods and Sales Tax (GST) for the proposed project.

“Around 60% of the cost would go towards materials, which attract GST and 9% on that is not much

in terms of tax. The State government wants this project, and so it would be their contribution towards the same. The land acquisition, if any, would be very minimal,” said a source. In February this year, during a meeting held by the Secretary, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, with the Tamil Nadu Chief Secretary, the NHAI accepted to take up the project, subject to a waiver of the State’s component of the GST. The modalities of implementation were being finalised along with the updation of the DPR, an of-

ficial source said. A retired Highways Department official said instead of an elevated corridor, it would be better to construct three flyovers at Puzhal covering Retteri Road, at Kavankarai, and at Sothupakkam junction covering Revathy Stores junction.

“An elevated corridor would would cost much higher than three flyovers. Since around 60% of vehicles using the road are two-wheelers, an elevated corridor won’t be of any help. Whereas flyovers will help reduce congestion at five junctions,” he added.



Reserve Bank of India
www.rbi.org.in
Department of Regulation
Nodal Regional Office, Rajaji Salai, Chennai – 600 001

Cancellation of Certificate of Registration - Public Notice

In exercise of the powers conferred under Section 45-IA (6) of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 (the Act), the Reserve Bank of India, by its order dated May 19, 2026, has cancelled the Certificate of Registration No. B-07.00104 dated November 30, 2017, issued to M/s Kiranglobal Business Investment Limited (bearing Corporate Identity Number (CIN) – L65921TN1993PLC024511, having its registered office at New No. 43, Old No. 22, P Block, 3rd Main Road, Anna Nagar, Chennai – 600 040) for carrying on the business of a Non-Banking Financial Institution as defined in section 45-I(a) of the Act. The company, therefore, cannot carry on the business of a Non-Banking Financial Institution under the Act.

A detailed list of registered NBFCs is available in our website (https://rbi.org.in/Scripts/BS_NBFCList.aspx).

This notice is issued in public interest.

Place: Chennai
Date: June 29, 2026

Sd/-
(R Kalavathi)
Deputy General Manager



भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
www.rbi.org.in
विनियमन विभाग
नोडल क्षेत्रीय कार्यालय, राजाजी साले, चेन्नै - 600 001

पंजीकरण प्रमाणपत्र रद्द करना - सार्वजनिक सूचना

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक अधिनियम, 1934 (अधिनियम) की धारा 45-आईए (6) के तहत प्रदत्त शक्तियों का प्रयोग करते हुए, भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक ने अपने 19 मई 2026 के आदेश द्वारा मैसर्स किरनग्लोबल बिजनेस इन्वेस्टमेंट लिमिटेड (कॉर्पोरेट पहचान नंबर - सीआईएन - L65921TN1993PLC024511), जिसका पंजीकृत कार्यालय नया नंबर 43, पुराना नंबर 22, पी ब्लॉक, तीसरा मेडन रोड, अण्णा नगर, चेन्नई – 600 040 में स्थित, को उक्त अधिनियम की धारा 45-आई(ए) में परिभाषित गैर-बैंकिंग वित्तीय संस्था का कारोबार करने के लिए जारी 30 नवंबर 2017 के पंजीकरण प्रमाणपत्र संख्या B-07.00104 को रद्द कर दिया गया है। अतः, उक्त कंपनी अब अधिनियम के तहत गैर-बैंकिंग वित्तीय संस्था का व्यवसाय नहीं कर सकती।

पंजीकृत एनबीएफसी की विस्तृत सूची, हमारी वेबसाइट (https://rbi.org.in/Scripts/BS_NBFCList.aspx) पर उपलब्ध है।

यह सूचना जनहित में जारी की गई है।

स्थान: चेन्नै
दिनांक: 29 जून 2026

**हस्ता-
(आर कलावती)**
उप महाप्रबंधक

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Clement Arockiasamy

A professor pauses mid-lecture. A slide remains half-explained, a thought suspended in the air. As a new academic year begins and campuses come alive once again, attention drifts not to the screen or the board, but to a student seated at the back, gazing out of the window. Is it disengagement, uncertainty, or a search for meaning that the lecture has not yet reached? In that fleeting moment, teaching reveals its deeper question: not what is being delivered, but what is truly being understood.

As colleges and universities reopen, beyond a return to schedules and syllabi and planning lectures lies a more fundamental inquiry: not just what we teach, but how and why we teach. Teaching cannot be measured solely by adherence to syllabus or method, nor only by outcomes such as grades or placements. It exists in the balance between what we aim to teach and what students truly carry forward.

Beyond content
For generations, the blackboard – and now the smartboard – has symbolised structured instruction: clarity, authority, direction. Yet in a world of abundant information, students no longer depend solely on teachers for access to knowledge. The educator’s role has expanded from delivering in-



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Beyond the board

Reimagining teaching in higher education at the beginning of a new academic year

formation to cultivating inquiry, from providing answers to framing meaningful questions. If higher education were only about degrees and employability, information delivery would suffice. But its purpose extends to preparing individuals to engage critically with ideas, navigate complexity, and contribute thoughtfully to society. A lecturer may transmit knowledge, but an educator shapes perspective.

Within the university ecosystem, the teacher re-

mains closest to the student’s intellectual journey. A single question, a moment of encouragement, or even a passing remark can shape how a student thinks long after the semester ends. As we look ahead to a future shaped by AI and constant change, certain capacities remain essential: critical thinking, communication, collaboration, and creativity.

Students today navigate academic pressure, social comparison, and digital distraction. Classrooms

must, therefore, become spaces where students feel respected, heard, and intellectually safe. Among all teaching skills, listening is the most vital. It is through listening that educators understand what students grasp, what they question, and what remains unspoken.

Intellectual investment
This broader vision also calls for a renewed commitment to intellectual depth on the part of educators. Lecturers who invest

in books, read beyond the syllabus, engage with diverse authors, and bring fresh perspectives into the classroom make a quiet but powerful academic investment. When students encounter ideas that go beyond the expected text, learning becomes less about coverage and more about discovery.

In many lecture halls, the challenge is not a lack of content, but a lack of engagement. The quiet student at the back – often seen as inattentive – may

reflect a deeper disconnect. Addressing this requires inclusive practices that draw in every learner. Even language matters: a word of encouragement can invite participation, while a careless remark can silence it.

The debate between memorisation and understanding remains relevant. Education must move beyond repetition toward application, analysis, and reflection.

Effective teaching rests on a balance between content, pedagogy, and the learner. An overloaded syllabus can restrict exploration, while excessive focus on method can dilute clarity. The student must remain at the centre, not as a passive recipient but as an active participant.

Teaching also involves knowing when to step back. As students grow, the educator’s role evolves from instructor to facilitator, from guide to collaborator. Ultimately, a teacher in higher education is also a mentor, a catalyst for inquiry, and a quiet influence on how students come to see the world.

The true measure of education lies not in what is written or displayed, but in what endures. Perhaps that student at the back is not disengaged at all but simply waiting for a reason to look up.

The writer is a Chevening Scholar, a graduate from the Institute of Development Studies at the University of Sussex, U.K., and a teacher trainer.

SCHOLARSHIPS

IDFC FIRST Bank MBA Scholarship
Offered by IDFC FIRST Bank.
Eligibility: Indian nationals residing in India and enrolled in the first year of a two-year full-time MBA programme in one of the 46 MBA colleges (check link below) with an annual family income not exceeding ₹600,000 from all sources. Applicants must have a valid mobile number linked to their Aadhaar number.
Rewards: ₹100,000 for each year of study
Application: Online
Deadline: July 8
www.b4s.in/edge/IFBMS7

AICTE Saksham Scholarship for Specially Abled Students
Offered by the All India Council for Technical Education.
Eligibility: Indian nationals from the specially-abled categories with a benchmark disability of 40% or more who have secured admission into a degree or diploma programme in AICTE-approved institutions in the current academic year and have an annual family income not exceeding not exceeding ₹800,000.
Rewards: ₹50,000 a year
Application: Online
Deadline: October 31
www.b4s.in/edge/ASST4
Courtesy: Buddy4study

AI Adoption Survey

QS I-GAUGE has launched an AI Adoption Survey for Educators, to assess educators’ perceptions of AI, their current usage patterns, and readiness to adopt AI in professional roles. The findings are expected to provide valuable national-level insights into how educational institutions can responsibly, effectively, and ethically integrate AI into academic ecosystems, even as AI

continues to reshape teaching, learning, assessment, research, and administrative functions.

Who can participate: Faculty members from schools across all educational boards, colleges, universities and other higher education institutions across India.

How to participate
Teachers from schools can visit <https://survey.zoho.com/public/in/zs/jmBM6>
Faculty from higher education institutions can visit <https://survey.zoho.com/public/in/zs/yzBMBR>

CM
Y
K

INBRIEF



Revanth, other leaders offer tributes to P.V. Narasimha Rao

Political leaders across party lines paid rich tributes to former Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao on his 105th birth anniversary on Sunday, recalling his contributions to nation-building and economic reforms. Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy paid floral tributes to Narasimha Rao's portrait at his residence in Jubilee Hills. Ministers Komatireddy Venkat Reddy and Adluri Laxman Kumar accompanied him.

A.P. issues policy guidelines for airport bars, liquor shops

The Andhra Pradesh government has issued guidelines for the grant of bar and liquor shop licences at airports in the State, excluding Tirupati Airport, based on a Group of Ministers' study of policies of other States. The policy allows airport bars and shops with 24/7 operations and flexible serving points, treating terminals as licensed premises. A graded Retail Excise Tax has been introduced – ₹25 lakh annually for bars at airports handling over 20 lakh passengers, ₹15 lakh for smaller airports, and ₹1 crore for liquor shops.

TTD cancels VIP, Srivani darshan amid huge rush

The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) has cancelled Monday's VIP Break Darshan and withdrawn the same-day online Srivani Darshan quota as part of a crowd-management exercise to cope with the unprecedented influx of pilgrims to Tirumala. The decision comes as the hill shrine witnesses one of the biggest pilgrim rushes in recent years. Over 1.5 lakh devotees were waiting for the darshan on Saturday.

Jigani murder: hunt on for woman's live-in partner

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The death of a 30-year-old Karnataka woman, initially treated as an unnatural death, has now been confirmed as murder after the post-mortem examination report.

The Jigani police have launched a manhunt for the prime suspect, who has been absconding since the incident.

The body of the victim, identified as Akshata Indragi, 30, from Ilkal in Bagalkote district, was found in a decomposed state at a rented house near Patalamma Temple in Jigani, on June 17. She had been staying in a house owned by municipal councillor Ramesh.

Neighbours alerted the house owner after noticing a foul smell and finding that the house had remained locked for nearly three days. The police initially registered a case of unnatural death.

CCTV footage later revealed that Akshata's live-in partner, identified as Nanne Saab, had left the house and gone missing after the incident. The house owner subsequently lodged a complaint expressing suspicion over her death.

The post-mortem report confirmed that Akshata had been strangled and assaulted before being murdered, prompting the police to register a murder case.

During the investigation, the police found that Saab was already married. They also discovered that Akshata had earlier been married to Krishna Indargi and had two children from that marriage.

Kerala Minister's support for PMAY logo kicks up a storm

K.M. Shaji's stand is in contrast to that of the previous LDF govt., which had opposed placing the emblem in front of houses built under the scheme, citing concern for the dignity of beneficiaries

S.R. Praveen
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The stand by the Minister for Local Self-Governments, K.M. Shaji, that the Kerala government was not opposed to the Centre's insistence on placing an emblem in front of houses built under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) has drawn sharp criticism from the Opposition.

The Minister's stand is in sharp contrast to that of the the previous LDF government, which had opposed the same, citing concern for the dignity of the beneficiaries of the housing scheme.

Mr. Shaji, who met presspersons on Sunday, claimed that reports which



said the PMAY emblem had Prime Minister Narendra Modi's photograph were wrong.

"I said there was nothing wrong with displaying the PMAY emblem. Can anyone show me a PMAY emblem carrying the Prime Minister's photograph? Over 1.2 lakh poor families will get new hous-

es under the scheme. Houses meant for the poor should not be blocked by creating unnecessary controversies in the name of an emblem," Mr. Shaji said.

He said that the previous government had withdrawn from the PMAY agreement not because of ideological reasons but due to its inability to pro-

See children as wealth, says CM Naidu

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has stressed the need for the joint family system to return, and said the government has been giving incentives to families to have two or more children, treating them as wealth at a time when the fertility rate is dropping.

Launching the national pulse polio immunisation drive by administering oral

polio drops to a few children at his residence on Sunday, Mr. Naidu said raising and looking after children should not be limited to women alone, and that, in the past, when there were joint families, everyone became partners in raising the young ones.

Share responsibility

He recalled that grandmothers, grandfathers and other family members played an important role in raising children with va-

lues, and said husbands and men must also take the responsibility of raising children, especially where women were working.

Mr. Naidu said the mind-set of viewing children as a burden must go, and that the situation was changing around the world, with children seen as wealth, keeping the future in view.

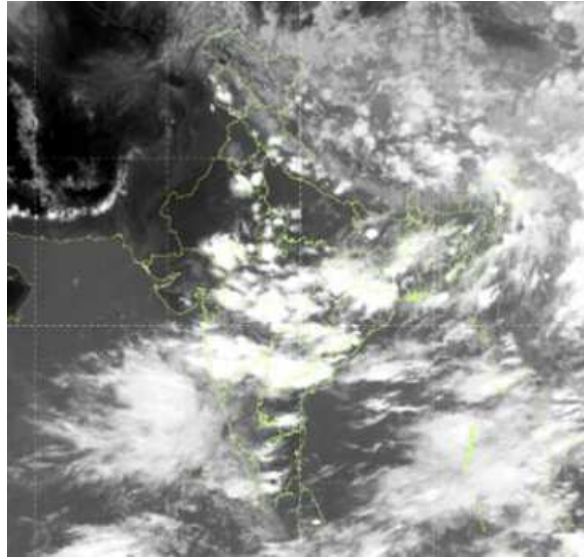
He advised parents to have all the vaccines provided by the government administered to their children as per schedule, to

protect them from crippling diseases.

Officials of the Department of Family Welfare told the Chief Minister that the drive was aimed at administering polio drops to about 49.2 lakh children under the age of five during the three-day programme. Commissioner of Family Welfare and other senior officials of the State Health Department and the National Health Mission were present.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to Very Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam & Meghalaya and Kerala & Mahe. Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Coastal Andhra Pradesh, Goa, Lakshadweep, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala				Kurnool		20.0	37.5
Ahmedabad				Lucknow		0.6	39.7
Alizawl		31.5	24	Madurai		40.0	27.5
Bengaluru		37.1	26.8	Mangaluru		7.6	28.2
Bhopal		37	24	Mumbai		6.2	32.4
Bhubaneswar		38.4	27.4	Mysuru		32.0	
Chandigarh		39.1	29.2	New Delhi		42.1	30.2
Chennai		37.8	25.6	Patna		39.6	00.0
Coimbatore		32.8	23.6	Port Blair		28.9	25.0
Dehradun		37.1	26.8	Prayagraj		43.4	30.0
Gangtok		41.2	21.6	Puducherry		38.7	26.9
Goa		28.4	29.4	Pune		4.1	33.0
Guwahati		32.3	27.5	Raipur		4.6	38.7
Hubballi		29	23	Ranchi		30.7	24.0
Hyderabad		35.8	26.2	Shillong		28.1	17.0
Imphal		29.9	23.7	Shimla		27.4	18.2
Jaipur		40.0	29.8	Srinagar		33.8	19.7
Kochi		56.8	28.8	Thiruvananthapuram		8.6	30.5
Kohima				Tiruchirappalli			
Kolkata		37.5	27.0	Vijayawada			
Kozhikode		5.2	28.8	Visakhapatnam		7.4	34.2

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	
Ahmedabad		6	7	21	35	107	In observation made at
Bengaluru		10	33	61		103	4.00 p.m., Panipat,
Chennai		5	11		43	67	Haryana recorded an
Delhi		13	53	72	84	149	overall air quality index
Hyderabad		7	12	33	44	76	(AQI) score of 366
Kolkata		5	21		45	47	indicating an unhealthy
Lucknow		7	28	57	143	94	level of pollution. In
Mumbai		23	20	101			contrast, Nahaarlagun,
Pune		21	86	29	29	46	Arunachal Pradesh
Visakhapatnam		14	52		62	118	recorded a healthy AQI
							score of 117

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Shivakumar-Kumaraswamy clash deepens over township project

Sharath S. Srivatsa
BENGALURU

The political battle for dominance in the Vokkaliga community – a major land-owning caste in Karnataka's Old Mysore region – has intensified, with the Bidadi Township Project emerging as a flashpoint.

While the initial opposition centred on farmers' concerns, it has now turned into a contest for one-upmanship among Vokkaliga leaders.

Though it was widely expected to become a thorny issue soon after Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar occupied the top post in the State Congress, his political rival and Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy has upped the ante, attracting wider attention within the farming community in south Karnataka. Both leaders are

from Bengaluru South district, of which Bidadi is a part.

The political narrative has turned messy, with allegations over Mr. Shivakumar's wealth countered by a poster campaign targeting Mr. Kumaraswamy and his family.

Mr. Kumaraswamy's actions are also being portrayed by the Congress as "smacking of jealousy", with a fellow Vokkaliga unable to stomach the rise of another leader from the community. Mr. Kumaraswamy on Sunday countered this by asking whether a leader should be allowed to "loot" simply because he is a Vokkaliga.

Incidentally, the project was conceived and notified by Mr. Kumaraswamy during his first term in 2006-07, a fact that is now being highlighted by the Congress. Mr. Shivaku-

mar has repeatedly said that he is not ready to "denotify it now and go to jail".

Mr. Kumaraswamy has vehemently denied that it is a clash of Vokkaliga personalities, maintaining that the opposition is only to the project. Party sources argued that the "soul and identity" of the Vokkaliga community was its land, and that the community had lost vast tracts of it as Bengaluru's landscape expanded rapidly over the last three decades.

"Our focus is to protect farmers from real estate interests. It is only incidental that about 80% of farmers in the region are Vokkaligas," a leader claimed.

He also pointed out that the project had been opposed by the Congress during Mr. Kumaraswamy's tenure.

Bhogapuram airport charges may be among country's highest

K. Srinivasa Rao
VIZIANAGARAM

Flying from the upcoming Bhogapuram International Airport of Andhra Pradesh, to be operated by GMR Airports Infrastructure Ltd., is likely to become more expensive, with passengers required to pay one of the highest User Development Fees (UDF) among major airports in the country.

According to representatives of air travellers' associations, Visakhapatnam airport – which will cease operations once the Bhogapuram airport becomes functional – currently does not levy any UDF. Passengers will have to bear not only higher travel costs to reach Bhogapuram in Vizianagaram district but also the additional UDF on both depar-



A view of the under-construction airport at Bhogapuram. FILE PHOTO

ture and arrival. The Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) has approved a UDF of ₹835 for departing domestic passengers and ₹355 for arriving domestic passengers at the airport.

For international travellers, the fee has been fixed at ₹1,255 for departures and ₹545 for arrivals. GMR-operated airport

in Hyderabad charges ₹750 as UDF for departing domestic passengers and ₹1,500 for departing international passengers, but does not levy any UDF on arriving passengers. Asked about the wide variation in UDF, a GMR spokesperson said that the charges were fixed in accordance with AERA's recommendations.

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Sunday called upon cadres to step up preparations for the upcoming municipal elections in Telangana, and urged them to intensify outreach efforts and position the party as an alternative to the ruling Congress and Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS).

On his visit to Hyderabad on Sunday, Mr. Nabin addressed a booth *pramukh sammelan* in

Nampally and also virtually inaugurated nine district offices from Rangareddy rural party office.

Addressing the *sammelan*, Mr. Nabin wanted cadres to prepare for a 'new struggle' based on service, sacrifice and commitment rather than power and privilege.

Stressing the importance of organisational strength, he said the BJP's success depended on its booth-level workers and reiterated the party slogan, '*booth jita toh chunav jitaa* (win the

booth, win the election)'. Greater Hyderabad and municipal polls are approaching, he said, adding that only the BJP can bring real development. "We want politics of development, not politics of dynasty and corruption," he said. Mr. Nabin said the Congress government had failed to fulfil promises made to the youth, particularly on employment, and charged both the Congress and BRS with pursuing vote-bank politics through their relationship with the AIMIM.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY



P. SRINIVASAN
aged 73 years,
Retd. Canara Bank employee,
passed away on 27-06-2026
at Bangalore, leaving behind
Vasanthi, Vyaas Narayanan,
Vinitra, Rajesh,
grandchildren and brothers.

DEATH



OBITUARY
Dr. G.B. Sukumaran
(10.01.1951 – 28.06.2026)
HOD (Retd), Dept. of Geology,
Presidency College, Chennai
passed away.
Deeply mourned by family.

DEATH

श्रीचक्रराज-निलया श्रीमल्लिपुरसुन्दरी
श्री-चक्रराज-निलया श्रीमल्लिपुरसुन्दरी
श्रीशिव-शिवशक्त्यैकरूपिणी ललिताम्बिका
श्री-शैवा-शैवा-शक्त्याैकरूपिणी ललिताम्बिका

In Loving Memory

KANAKAM DEVAGUPTAPU
29-06-1952 to 27-06-2026

Our beloved mother and wife of Sri. Seshagiri Rao Devaguptapu, merged into the loving embrace of Sri Lalita Mahatripurasundari on 27-06-2026.
Final rites on 29-06-2026 at the Besant Nagar Crematorium, Chennai.

Deeply mourned by Family & Friends.
Aparna, Divya & Upendra

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
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Children and grandchildren

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8th ANNIVERSARY
In Everlasting memory of



Smt. Durga Chandrasekaran
Founder, Durga Driving School
16.10.1957 - 29.06.2018
You will live in our hearts forever
fondly remembered by
Husband : Chandrasekaran
Sons : Srikanth & Vijay
Daughters-in-law : Deepika & Meena
Grandson : Rishaan Vijay
Friends & Relatives
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Buyer beware

Tracking down defective batches of drugs is essential

The Health Ministry’s notification to expand Schedule H2 drugs to entire therapeutic classes now from a curated list of brands earlier is a commendable change from regulating based on revenue to regulating based on risk. The government had introduced Schedule H2 in 2022-23, which required a barcode or QR code on each pack of specific drugs to verify the pack’s authenticity. It is part of a framework that also touches on regulating active pharmaceutical ingredients and export-oriented pharmaceutical compliance. Now, with the additional symbols encoding a product identifier, the manufacturing licence number, batch number, and other details, authorities hope to better track down defective batches. Counterfeit networks have long targeted vaccines, cancer medicines and antimicrobials, with WHO flagging high volumes of fake antimicrobials in low- and middle-income countries. India has one of the world’s highest antimicrobial resistance rates, and sub-standard antimicrobials can lead to sub-therapeutic dosing, exerting selection pressure on resistant strains. The Narcotics Control Bureau has also expressed concerns about medicinal opioids and psychotropic substances ‘leaking’ into illicit markets. The government will hope that the new system addresses the U.S. FDA’s and the European Medicines Agency’s recurring concerns about quality control, an issue on which India has found itself on the back foot over contaminated cough syrups. The U.S. Trade Representative has also repeatedly identified India as a leading source of counterfeit medicines, with many fake pharmaceuticals seized at the U.S. border originating from or transiting through India.

Together with policy changes effected by the Jan Vishwas Act 2026, the new framework finally distinguishes between procedural non-compliance and substantial non-compliance, considering only the latter constitutes meaningful enforcement. In the long term, the government should rationalise the compliance burden and eliminate the risk of corruption associated with discretionary enforcement. The government must also recognise that the QR code system will only be effective if backed by a state-managed database that pharmacists and regulators can access in real time, supported by interoperable software and scanning infrastructure across States. Second, pharmacists and consumers must develop a habit of verifying medicines before a sale. Third, the compliance needs imposed by new packaging requirements and the IT integration will strain MSME manufacturers in particular. Finally, prescription data on controlled substances is sensitive information and will need to be handled with a digital governance layer that does not yet exist. Thus, whether the new framework will improve India’s reputation as a pharmacy comes down to its implementation.

Sharing waters

The Tungabhadra dam is a good example of inter-State cooperation

The coming together of the Chief Ministers of Karnataka (D.K. Shivakumar), Telangana (A. Revanth Reddy) and Andhra Pradesh (N. Chandrababu Naidu), along with Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Patil, at the inauguration of the 33 spillway gates of the Tungabhadra dam on June 25 was significant beyond the optics. The three leaders pledged greater inter-State cooperation, which is welcome given that the dam has largely remained free of major disputes due to an established water-sharing formula and the Tungabhadra Board’s regulation of releases. Located in Karnataka’s Koppal district, the dam is considered to be the lifeline of the three southern States, providing irrigation to about 16.4 lakh acres – 9.26 lakh in Karnataka, 6.25 lakh in Andhra Pradesh, and 87,000 in Telangana. It hit the headlines in August 2024 when a crest gate was washed away during heavy inflows – which also happened when the dam was full with 105 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft) of water. The damaged gate was replaced with a temporary one, but with much water wasted, the authorities, who did not want to take chances with the other 32 gates, chose to install high-grade steel gates, at ₹51 crore and which are expected to last 60 years.

Notwithstanding the bonhomie, the differences among the leaders on some issues concerning the larger Tungabhadra project cannot be brushed aside. The Upper Bhadra project, a major lift irrigation scheme under implementation in the central region of Karnataka and upstream of the Tungabhadra dam, has emerged as an irritant for Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. At one stage, the BJP-led Union government had made a provision of ₹5,300 crore in its budget for 2023-24, a few months before the Karnataka Assembly elections. However, the Centre later chose not to include it under any of its schemes, but this is being implemented by a Karnataka government undertaking. It remains to be seen whether the spirit of camaraderie will help the three neighbours to overcome their differences on the Upper Bhadra issue. The Tungabhadra dam is also facing excessive siltation, which has reduced its storage capacity from the original 133 tmc ft to about 106 tmc ft. Mr. Patil has assured the Chief Ministers about the Centre’s plan to remove silt from water reservoirs across the country including the Tungabhadra. More importantly, the Union government should closely monitor and expedite, wherever required, the execution of dam rehabilitation and improvement projects being taken up in 19 States. Any laxity with regard to dam safety may have disastrous consequences. The focus must be on prevention, not reparation.

In his profound encyclical, *Magnifica Humanitas*, Pope Leo XIV grounds the contemporary crisis of technology in elemental theology, reminding humanity that the individual stands at the absolute centre of divine creation. Yet, this sacred human dignity faces an unprecedented challenge. The Holy Father warns that artificial intelligence (AI), left unchecked, threatens to turn the ownership of our personal data into a new form of digital slavery – a subjugation as cruel as human bondage. Because the stakes are so inherently tied to human dignity, the Pontiff insists that the governance of AI cannot rely on vague good intentions, nor can it be left to the private consciences of the engineers who build these systems. Instead, he issues an urgent call for robust, binding law over abstract ethics, independent public oversight over the empty promises of Silicon Valley’s modern pharaohs – and a clear requirement that a human being remains accountable whenever an automated system decides who gets a loan, a job, a medical bed, or an education. Pope Leo XIV’s core demand is that this new electronic Curia be strictly regulated rather than quietly surrendered to a handful of private tech monopolies whose reach and resources already outstrip most sovereign governments. He even goes so far as to commend the courage to deliberately slow down the development of AI.

When regulation lags

However, a fundamental problem remains: AI and morality do not observe the same time. AI is developed at the breakneck speed of the start-up culture, driven by an ethos to move fast and run perpetual beta tests on society in the guise of progress. This velocity is fuelled not just by commercial rivalries, but by relentless mathematical innovation spanning from Silicon Valley to Shenzhen. It presents a deeper hurdle for lawmakers worldwide: parliament can govern what a person does, but it can never forbid a mathematical theorem, a discovery, or an equation from being made. How do lawmakers fulfil the Pope’s wishes?

Law in most democracies moves slowly. By the time landmark legislation such as the European Union’s Artificial Intelligence Act or the United Kingdom’s Online Safety Act were painstakingly debated and passed, the specific technical harms they were built to combat had already mutated, leaving an entire generation to grow up inside unaddressed digital vulnerabilities. Policymakers have historically been behind the innovation curve, and under current paradigms, we will be again.

If legislation is fated to lag behind innovation, the consequences for democratic societies are not merely regulatory; they are existential. Democracy cannot function if citizens cannot distinguish reality from fabrication. At its core, democratic governance relies on a shared epistemic foundation: a collective agreement on



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including, most recently, ‘The Sage Who Reimagined Hinduism: The Life, Lessons and Legacy of Sree Narayana Guru’

Unchecked AI threatens democracy, demanding constitutional safeguards beyond conventional regulation

basic facts from which public debate, policy, and electoral choices can flow. When that foundation is systematically undermined, the entire democratic project is threatened. Today, AI-generated disinformation and advanced synthetic media (“deepfakes”) have advanced to a level of fidelity where the human eye and ear can no longer reliably detect forgery. This is already our reality. Highly convincing audio and video duplications of political leaders are deployed strategically during sensitive electoral cycles to depress voter turnout, fabricate scandals out of thin air, and instantly shatter public trust in legitimate state institutions.

This vulnerability is hyper-charged by algorithmic manipulation. Big Tech platforms operate on business models engineered exclusively to maximise user engagement. Because outrage, fear, and sensationalism generate the highest click-through rates, platform algorithms systematically prioritise and amplify hyper-partisan content, driving radicalisation. By trapping citizens within hyper-customised echo chambers, these systems normalise online hate and accelerate social fragmentation. In doing so, private platforms exert an unprecedented form of unaccountable power, effectively rewriting the rules of the public square to optimise quarterly corporate profits at the expense of social cohesion.

Democracy’s digital vulnerability

When a society is deeply polarised and stripped of a shared reality, it becomes a soft target for foreign interference. Adversarial nation-states and non-state actors have weaponised these platform vulnerabilities, transforming them into a theatre for sophisticated information warfare. Foreign information manipulation operations are no longer clumsy, bot-driven spam campaigns; they are highly targeted, AI-driven psychological operations designed to covertly exploit pre-existing religious, ethnic, or socioeconomic fault lines within a target nation. By covertly funding, generating, and amplifying divisive narratives, hostile foreign actors can destabilise a democracy from within, turning its own citizens against one another. These coordinated campaigns represent nothing less than a direct, strategic threat to democratic sovereignty itself. As the world’s largest democracy and a global technology hub, India stands at the absolute epicentre of this crisis. In an environment where digital adoption outpaces structural digital literacy, the weaponisation of synthetic media and algorithmic polarisation poses a unique threat to India’s pluralistic society.

If traditional, reactive legislation is doomed to always trail behind mathematical innovation, India cannot rely on standard, backward-looking regulatory frameworks. Instead, an enduring law and policy framework for India must be anchored in five foundational pillars that operate concurrently.

First, AI governance must adopt a strictly

rights-based framework that prioritises individual human dignity and digital autonomy, ensuring citizens possess unalienable rights over their personal data, strict consent protocols, and clear protections against algorithmic discrimination in critical sectors such as employment, credit, and health care. Second, platforms must be subjected to genuine democratic accountability; large technology firms can no longer hide behind absolute safe-harbour immunities while their algorithms profit from the viral spread of destabilising disinformation. They must be legally compelled to introduce structural transparency, allowing independent audits of their recommendation engines and forcing them to accept systemic liability for algorithmic amplification that results in real-world violence.

Third, even as these frameworks are constructed, free speech protections must remain fully intact. The power to define and combat disinformation must never devolve into a tool for state-sponsored censorship or the silencing of political dissent. The focus of regulation must remain strictly on structural platform mechanics, such as automated bot networks and deepfake originators, rather than the heavy-handed policing of individual ideological speech.

Fourth, because technical fixes are entirely insufficient without building cognitive resilience within the populace, India must launch a massive, state-backed educational initiative focused on media literacy and digital citizenship. This curriculum must be integrated across schools, universities, and rural community centres to train citizens to critically evaluate digital sources and identify emotional manipulation tactics. Finally, to defend national sovereignty, India must establish sophisticated, cross-sector early-warning systems capable of detecting coordinated misinformation operations in real-time. By leveraging advanced detection tools and fostering deep collaboration between state security apparatuses, independent fact-checking networks, and ethical hackers, the nation can identify and neutralise foreign information warfare campaigns before they achieve viral velocity.

A constitutional imperative

Ultimately, the lesson of our era is clear: AI governance cannot remain merely regulatory or technical. It is a profound mistake to treat the manipulation of the information ecosystem as a series of isolated technical glitches to be patched with minor corporate updates or narrow statutory tweaks. Because these technologies possess the unique capability to distort truth, polarise societies, and erode the sovereign choice of voters, AI governance must rise to the level of a constitutional imperative. The right to an unmanipulated information ecosystem, where reality can be clearly distinguished from corporate or state fabrication, must be viewed as an indispensable extension of the fundamental right to life, liberty, and free expression.

July opens the biggest chapter in India-U.K. trade ties

Trade deals are important for accelerating prosperity but not every deal is a game changer. One that drives shared growth across key sectors, unlocks opportunity for businesses of all sizes, and pushes the envelope for bilateral trade qualifies to achieve that tag. And so, it is no surprise to see businesses and trade associations using the term in relation to the United Kingdom-India Free Trade Agreement (FTA) which is formally known as Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA). India remains the fastest-growing economy in the G-20 and it is on track to become the world’s third-largest economy within the next five years. Complementing this the U.K. remains one of the top global destinations for investment and was the third fastest-growing economy in the G-7 in 2025. Securing preferential access to each other’s market is not an abstract diplomatic win; it is an economic advantage that will deliver significant returns in both countries over time. This FTA is forecast to boost Indian GDP by ₹5.1 billion, the U.K.’s GDP by ₹4.8 billion and increase bilateral trade by ₹25.5 billion every year in the long run.

Bilateral trade was already worth £48 billion a year in 2025. From July 15, it will be cheaper, quicker, and easier for businesses to trade across both countries. Even before this deal came into force, we have seen the creation of thousands of new jobs on both sides and that is showing no signs of slowing down, as the countdown to entry into force closes and a new era of growth between the two nations begins. We should all be excited to see what the two countries and businesses on both sides can achieve in the years ahead. These are the hallmarks of a historic deal; but it is not just about the numbers.

A story of scale and depth

From day one, both sides agreed that this deal must be broad, deep, and a driving force that brings long-term growth for both countries. Nearly three years of intensive negotiations



Harjinder Kang

His Majesty’s Trade Commissioner for South Asia and the British Deputy High Commissioner for western India

The U.K.-India Free Trade Agreement, the ‘gold standard of modern trade deals’, comes into force on July 15

preceded this deal and there is no doubt that the agreement reached is the most economically significant trade deal that the U.K. has done since leaving the European Union; it is also one of the most comprehensive trade deals that India has ever done. In short it is a win-win for businesses and consumers and for both economies. To give readers just a flavour of the far-reaching benefits – 99% of U.K. tariff lines will be duty-free for Indian products and India will remove or reduce tariffs on 90% of its tariff lines for U.K. products.

For India, this could support jobs in labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, leather, jewellery and, equally, it will boost exports in services such as IT and finance by a large margin.

Similarly, tariff duties on U.K. exports to India are estimated to fall by around £400 million when the deal comes into effect, and further to £900 million in later phases. Critical industries such as aerospace, automobiles, medical devices, and whiskies will all benefit significantly, adding billions to the U.K. economy. This is transformational and it is also just the beginning.

Benefits beyond Mumbai and London

One of the most persistent criticisms of trade policy is that the gains created are only concentrated in a few places. We have ensured that this deal benefits all aspects of the local economy beyond the major cities in both countries. Several unprecedented and dedicated provisions across high-growth and high-value sectors from each side are agreed in a deal spanning 30 chapters. In practical terms, that means manufacturers, innovators, supply chain businesses, and service exporters – often based far away from the major cities – can compete more effectively with cheaper imports and fewer barriers. For instance, a textile manufacturer from Indore, Madhya Pradesh, will now be able to trade more efficiently into the U.K. just like an auto-parts manufacturer from Birmingham will be able to trade more cost effectively into India.

Modern trade goes beyond just tariffs and that is why this agreement’s provisions on customs, digital trade, and services are central to its exceptional standard. Improved customs provisions will help goods reach markets faster – particularly valuable for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) that cannot afford excessive red tape. On services, where the U.K. is globally renowned, the agreement locks in market access across key sectors, providing the predictability that U.K. businesses need to expand in India and vice versa. The deal also includes India’s first-ever standalone chapters on anti-corruption, gender, and development – and one of the most comprehensive labour and environmental commitments that India has ever made in a trade deal. But it is not just about access; it is also about securing appropriate protections for domestic producers, which is what this deal does so well.

For instance, India maintains protections for dairy products and edible oils, while the U.K. shields sugar, milled rice, pork, chicken, and eggs. In an era where trade agreements are judged not only on growth but also on sustainability and fairness, this deal shows how it is done.

Making the deal count

It is clear that this landmark deal combines measurable economic gains, deep market access in the sectors of the future, practical trade facilitation, strong domestic protections, and the first-of-their-kind values chapters. It sets a template for what modern trade agreements should look like: pro-growth, pro-worker, pro-innovation – a gold standard for trade deals.

As we close in on entry into force, the task is clear: let us maximise it. Businesses from both countries should champion exports, explore procurement opportunities, map supply chains against new rules of origin, and move quickly because in trade, first-mover advantage is real, and it rarely comes twice.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Ayodhya fund case

Reports of alleged irregularities in the handling of funds raised for the Ram temple in Ayodhya demand urgent public scrutiny (Front page, June 27). Thousands of donors across the country contributed in good faith to a cause

presented as both religious and civic. Transparency and accountability are non-negotiable when public contributions are involved. A shrine built on collective faith deserves an administrative framework beyond reproach. The authorities must thoroughly

investigate these allegations and take swift corrective action to restore public confidence.

Kshirasagara Balaji Rao, Hyderabad

Temple fund scandals are seldom the work of a few dishonest individuals alone.

They are usually a combination of omission and commission: systemic loopholes are either deliberately created or conveniently left unattended. Cash-intensive institutions demand the highest standards of transparency, independent

audits, digital accounting, CCTV-backed custody chains, and clear segregation of responsibilities. When these safeguards fail, faith itself becomes collateral damage. The lesson is that sacred institutions must be governed by systems so

robust that temptation finds no opportunity and dishonesty no refuge.

R. Narayanan, Navi Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

How schools can tackle adolescent malnutrition

As schools across the country reopened after summer vacation, classrooms were filled once again with the energy, aspirations and anxieties of millions of adolescents. Yet hidden behind their growing ambitions lies a silent public health emergency – adolescent malnutrition. The recently released NFHS-6 (2023-24) findings are stark. Obesity among women aged 15-49 years has risen from 24% to 30.7%, and among men from 22.9% to 27.3%. High blood sugar among men aged 15 and above jumped from 15.6% to 20.9%, and among women from 13.5% to 17.8%. What is most alarming is that lifestyle changes once associated with cities and affluent communities such as sedentary behaviour, processed diets, stress and rising obesity, are now affecting rural populations too. India faces a double burden: undernutrition among children and surging obesity among adults, with obesity driving diabetes, heart disease and stroke. These crises do not begin in adulthood. Their roots lie in adolescence, making schools the most critical setting for prevention.

Addressing diets differently
Schools must recognise that malnutrition is no longer only about thinness. India is witnessing the ‘thin-fat’ phenotype – children who appear lean yet carry dangerous metabolic risk. According to the Comprehensive National Nutrition Survey (CNNS, 2019), 27.4% of Indian adolescents are stunted. At the same time, obesity is rising, particularly among the urban youth. More strikingly, 35% of children under five are stunted yet carry adult-level triglycerides, which is like a metabolic time bomb associated with adult-onset diabetes and cardiovascular disease. Preventing these diseases must begin in school, not in hospitals decades later. Studies on Delhi school adolescents confirmed that the



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Scientist G at the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition and leads the Let'sFixOurFood Initiative



Bharati Kulkarni

Director, ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition

Schools are not merely educational institutions; they have the potential to be powerful public health promoting institutions

consumption of milk and dairy products, green leafy vegetables and fruits is lower than what is recommended. Far too many children consume cereal-heavy diets while proteins and protective foods remain woefully inadequate. Schools can address this through improved midday meals, healthier canteens and food demonstrations that teach students how to build balanced plates. The Dietary Guidelines for Indians 2024 recommend that half the plate by volume should consist of fruits and vegetables. Yet research confirms that sedentary and screen-heavy behaviours are inversely associated with daily fruit and vegetable intake – a dangerous compounding effect. School gardens, fruit breaks, and local seasonal produce can normalise healthier eating habits.

Addressing sugar and UPFs
Moreover, the bitter truth about sugar has to be revealed. Sugary drinks, High fat sugar and salt (HFSS) foods, and Ultra-Processed Foods (UPFs) are rapidly replacing traditional foods. Studies highlight alarming trends in free sugar and UPF consumption among Indian adolescents. A recent World Health Organization study has revealed that UPF consumption in India has been surging at more than 13.7% year-after-year. The bitter truth is that the excess sugar consumed today becomes a metabolic risk tomorrow. Schools must actively discourage sugary beverages and display sugar boards showing hidden sugar content. Reinforcement, not one-time campaigns, converts knowledge into practice. Physical inactivity must be treated as seriously as poor diet. Schools should guarantee structured physical activity and sports as core educational components, not optional extras. This is especially urgent as urban lifestyle habits such as reduced movement, changing diets, and rising obesity are now affecting rural communities too, making inactivity a nationwide epidemic, not only city schools' problem.

Thus, among the most common risk factors for non-communicable diseases in children and adolescents are unhealthy diets and insufficient physical activity. The rapid rise of adolescent obesity increases the risk of early-onset Type 2 diabetes, hypertension and heart disease, and will lead to substantially greater healthcare spending. UPF-free school zones must become a national movement backed by consistent policy.

Schools advancing public health
It is here that the Let's Fix Our Food (LFOF) initiative offers a compelling direction. Led by the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN), the LFOF consortium is a multi-stakeholder initiative working to create healthier food environments for adolescents by advancing evidence-based policy, empowering youth through nutrition literacy, and campaigning for regulatory frameworks. Its outputs include recommendations for regulating HFSS food advertising, taxation on unhealthy beverages, a model school nutrition curriculum and a food label reading kit. A 2025 *Lancet* study projected that 21.8 crore men and 23.1 crore women in India will be overweight by 2050, with the steepest rise expected among adolescents and young adults aged 15-24 years. Schools must move beyond textbook nutrition education and adopt skill-based approaches such as reading food labels, recognising portion sizes, understanding marketing tactics, and basic cooking. Schools are not merely educational institutions; they have the potential to be powerful public health promoting institutions. School-based interventions in India have demonstrated measurable improvements in dietary behaviour and reductions in sugary beverage consumption. A child protected from unhealthy diets today is far less likely to become a patient tomorrow.

The politics around custodial deaths

The Opposition in Andhra Pradesh is attacking the government on its excesses

STATE OF PLAY

Sumit Bhattacharjee

The recent alleged custodial death of a person at the Krishnalanka police station in Vijayawada in the NTR district of Andhra Pradesh is turning out to be a major political issue.

Gade Sai Krishna, who, according to the police, has a criminal history, was picked up by the Circle Inspector of Krishnalanka police station, S.S.V.V. Nagaraju, on May 9 from his residence in Markapuram for questioning in connection with some old cases. He has been missing since then. G. Vijaya Lakshmi, mother of Sai Krishna, after making repeated rounds to the police station to inquire about the whereabouts of her son, filed a *habeas corpus* petition in the Andhra Pradesh High Court on June 2. Based on the petition, the court ordered the NTR Police Commissionerate to produce Sai Krishna by June 15. Upon failing to meet the deadline, the High Court further directed the police to produce him on June 29.

In the meantime, voices of protest grew louder and the Opposition parties, including the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) and the Congress, left no stone unturned in blaming the administration and the government. They shaped the narrative as one of custodial torture and death, which, they claimed, was being hushed up by the police.

Ever since the incident started gaining prominence, former Chief Minister and YSRCP president Jagan Mohan Reddy has sought to highlight, what he describes as, police excesses under the ruling party and has even gone to the extent of accusing the govern-



ment of “Red Book” governance. It may be recalled that during the run-up to the 2024 elections, the present IT Minister Nara Lokesh had spoken of a “Red Book,” indicating that he had noted down incidents and the names of people who had reportedly committed excesses during the YSRCP rule and that, once in power, he would deal with them suitably.

Same playbook?
Not long ago, during the 2024 election campaign, a similar murder case had become the Achilles’ heel of then Chief Minister Jagan Reddy. His own Member of Legislative Council (MLC), Ananta Satya Udaya Bhaskar, popularly known as Ananta Babu, was involved in the murder of his driver, Subrahmanyam. Chandrababu Naidu, then in the Opposition, and Jana Sena Party (JSP) leader Pawan Kalyan had turned the issue into a major political talking point during their election campaign. As the deceased man was Dalit, they targeted Mr. Reddy and his party leaders by accusing them of being biased against the Dalit community. The issue became a major political plank for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the run-up to the 2024 election campaign. While this incident may not have been the tipping point for Mr. Reddy’s rout in the elections, it did play a role and

may have contributed to the polarisation of Dalit voters, particularly in the Godavari districts, where the community has a significant vote share. While Ananta Babu’s case was turned into a caste-based political narrative, Sai Krishna’s case may not evolve into one. Both the accused and the victim belong to the same community, and there is no apparent political angle to it, though the Opposition is trying its best to give it a political twist. What exactly happened to Sai Krishna is still not known, as neither his whereabouts nor his body (if he is dead) has been found. In the meantime, a seasoned Mr. Naidu has taken stock of the situation and appears to be dealing with it firmly. The Chief Minister inquired into the incident in detail and directed DGP Harish Kumar Gupta to suspend Mr. Nagaraju. Subsequently, the police registered a murder case against the CI, and he was taken into custody on June 23. Further, the Government constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to investigate the alleged illegal detention, custodial death, and destruction of evidence in Sai Krishna’s case. Mr. Naidu also met the mother of the missing youth and assured her of a transparent investigation. The challenge before the ruling alliance is to prevent the controversy from turning into a larger political debate. While the authorities concerned have so far taken the necessary action and set the course of the narrative, much depends on fast-tracking the investigation and bringing it to a logical conclusion before the Opposition can transform it into a political rallying point in the days ahead.

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Will a survey error threaten the credibility of govt. schools?

The finding that government schools are charging fees in rural areas is at odds with all existing government policy and needs to be properly investigated

DATA POINT

Anish Gupta Gaurav Deepti Kushwaha

In a written question in the Rajya Sabha earlier this year, an MP highlighted that 27% of students in government schools are paying fees – including admission, tuition, examination and development charges – and sought a response from the Ministry of Education. The MP’s claim was based on the findings of the Comprehensive Modular Survey: Education (CMS-E), conducted by the National Statistics Office as part of the 80th round of the National Sample Survey (NSS) from April-June 2025 (**Charts 1 and 2**). The finding that a sizeable share of students, even in government schools, paid fees surprised many, since it could suggest that those schools were illegally charging fees, raising concerns over the implementation of the Right to Education (RTE) Act, which mandates free education for all children up to age 14. The survey covered 52,085 households, including 28,401 in rural areas. This article examines whether government schools are indeed charging such fees, or whether the findings reflect issues related to data collection, compilation or both. To identify the source of the problem, the average course fees paid by students in rural and urban areas were compared using education expenditure data for students in Classes 1 to 8, who are covered under the RTE Act. For the analysis, the course fees reported in the survey – which include admission fees, tuition fees, examination fees, development fees and other compulsory payments – were classified into four categories: no fees, ₹1-₹5,000, ₹5,001-₹10,000 and above ₹10,000. The analysis showed that, among those reporting course fees

above ₹10,000, the average course fee paid by students in government schools in rural areas was higher than that paid by their counterparts in private schools. Second, the data across all four course-fee categories showed that the percentage difference in average total educational expenditure between students in government and private schools ranged from -50.4% to +4.0% in rural areas and from -57.2% to +34.3% in urban areas (**Table 1**). Both points challenge the widely held perception that students in government schools incur substantially lower educational expenses than those in private schools. Third, several States reported unusually low proportions of students with no course fees in government schools. In rural areas, the share of such students is particularly low – in Ladakh (0%), Tripura (2.6%), West Bengal (43%) and Kerala (53%). Fourth, the percentage of students with no course fees in government schools is substantially lower in rural areas than in urban areas. For instance, in Himachal Pradesh this was 55.6% and 78.3% respectively, with similar patterns observed in six other States, which is difficult to reconcile with any existing government policy.

Possible problems
A commonly cited explanation for such discrepancies is data-collection error. First, even when survey investigators understand the intended meaning of the questions, they may struggle to communicate it to respondents in the same context in which they were designed. For example, a key question on educational expenditure in this survey is Question 9(i) in Block 5. It asks about “course fees”, which include admission fees, tuition fees, examination fees, development fees and other compulsory payments. Interestingly, in common usage, the term “tuition fees” is often understood to mean fees paid

for private coaching or supplementary education. However, in school education, “tuition fees” refers to payments made to schools for teachers’ salaries and basic academic resources. While the survey intends to capture this, respondents may have reported spending on private coaching as tuition fees. Second, information was collected using Computer-Assisted Personal Interviewing (CAPI), under which responses are recorded directly on tablets. While this approach may facilitate faster processing, it also introduces certain limitations. For example, in earlier paper-based NSS surveys, enumerators could leave questions blank when respondents gave no answer. With CAPI, non-response is generally not permitted, and enumerators must enter a value before proceeding. Previous surveys suggest that non-response, resulting in missing observations, was not uncommon and in the NSS 75th Round (2017), it was 39.4%. However, there were no missing observations in 80th Round of survey, which used CAPI. This raises the possibility that some course-fee values may have been entered merely to proceed to the next question. Moreover, even minor modifications may disrupt the process, and features such as autocorrect can sometimes distort recorded responses. Even the World Bank has noted that CAPI systems can be highly rigid. If a large number of students do not have access to free education, the issue warrants serious scrutiny. Yet it is surprising that, despite the matter being raised in Parliament, neither the Central government nor any State government has come forward to investigate. Conversely, if the findings result from flaws in data collection and validation, as the evidence above suggests, those responsible must be held accountable. Such errors not only distort policy research but also tarnish the reputation of government schools and teachers.

Misleading data?

The data for the charts were sourced from the NSS 80th round, the Comprehensive Modular Survey: Education (CMS:E), 2025



Students arrive at a government high school in Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh after the summer vacation on June 12. G.N. RAO.

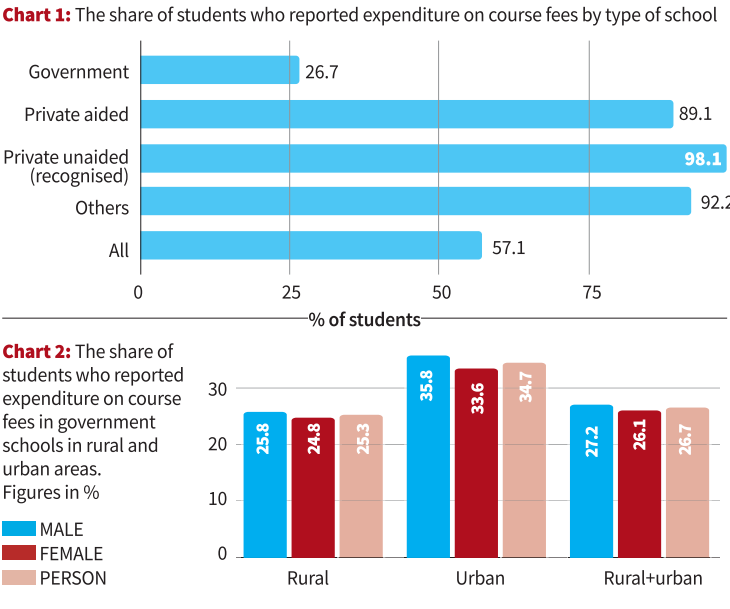


Table 1: Average total expenditure by course fee categories (in ₹)

Course Fee category	School type	Average exp on course fee		Average total expenditure	
		Rural	Urban	Rural	Urban
0	Government	0	0	1,824	2,470
	Private (aided & unaided)	0	0	3,677	5,767
1-5000	Government	736	1,009	3,920	5,255
	Private (aided & unaided)	2,621	2,800	7,866	8,200
5001-10000	Government	6,917	6,827	15,839	19,956
	Private (aided & unaided)	7,595	7,837	15,236	14,857
Above 10000	Government	24,000	19,443	31,850	30,856
	Private (aided & unaided)	22,608	28,458	35,742	41,452

Based on authors' calculations

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 29, 1976

Seychelles attains Independence today

Victoria (Seychelles), June 28: “The String of Pearls”, a group of 92 islands of Seychelles in the western Indian Ocean will take its rightful place in the comity of nations when it attains independence to-morrow after centuries of French and British Colonial domination. A new chapter will unfold in the lives of 68,000 Seychellois people when the President, Mr. James R. Mancham, will raise the flag of the world’s youngest nation at a colourful ceremony in Victoria, marking yet another great victory for a member of the third world. Delegations from all parts of the world have gathered in picturesque Victoria, capital of Seychelles, to represent their respective nations on this historic occasion. India is represented by the Minister of State for Tourism and Civil Aviation, Mr. Surendra Pal Singh, and the Indian High Commissioner to Kenya, Air Chief Marshal Arjan Singh. The Seychelles archipelago has a land area of only 279 sq.km but stretches across 3,88,000 sq. km. The climate in the islands, despite their proximity to the equator, is equable. Although the islands were probably known to seafarers as early as 916, they remained uninhabited for several centuries. The establishment of the first French colony in 1770 brought Seychelles in the path of Anglo-French rivalry in the Indian Ocean. After no fewer than seven capitulations to the British, the period of French rule finally ended in 1814 when Seychelles became a dependency of the British colony of Mauritius.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JUNE 29, 1926

Raw cotton in the Madras presidency

The receipts of loose cotton at presses and spinning mills in the Madras Presidency from 30th January to 18th June 1926 amounted to 250,446 bales of 400 lb lint against an estimate of 551,400 bales of the total crop of 1925-26. The receipts in the corresponding period of the previous year were 311,321 bales. 30,642 bales mainly of pressed cotton were received at spinning mills and 123,701 bales were exported by sea, while 11,730 bales were imported by sea from Karachi and Bombay.

From Page One

‘Shared responsibility must for Indian Ocean’

“The Global South, and especially the island nations, are the most impacted by climate change. Its effects are already visible on our coastlines, in the marine ecosystems, in weather patterns, and in our communities,” he said.

“We will continue to explore new opportunities for the industries of both our countries. We will also work towards enhancing connectivity between India and the Seychelles. This will not only boost our bilateral trade but also strengthen our ties with East Africa and the Indian Ocean region,” he said.

The Prime Minister, who is on a three-day visit to the archipelagic nation, attended the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles as the Guest of Honour.

Earlier in the day, at a special ceremony, Mr. Modi was also conferred with ‘Guardian of the Blue Horizon’ by Mr. Herminie for his “green leadership and efforts towards advancing the interests of developing countries and his longstanding commitment towards promoting the blue economy”.

The outcomes after the talks on Sunday included an extradition treaty, an agreement on cooperation in the peaceful uses of outer space, an agreement to advance UPI-based digital payments in the Seychelles, an umbrella line of credit agreement with the Export-Import Bank of India and an agreement for preliminary preparations for a new the Seychelles National Hospital, according to the Ministry of External Affairs.

Ayodhya row: houses of 8 accused searched

“The Chief Minister who was setting a world record in visiting Ayodhya still did not get this information even after going there. That is why the proverb was made – darkness under the lamp. How many times has he gone there, and yet he has no news of this. What are the State intelligence agencies and police force doing? This shows complete lack of competence,” said Mr. Yadav.

In response, Mr. Adityanath said the SP government fired upon Ram Bhakts. “Those who speak of making Ayodhya a religious city should first look at their own history. The SP government that had Ram devotees fired upon, opposed the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, stopped Shri Krishna Janmashtami celebrations, and even banned the Kanwar Yatra is today talking about making Ayodhya a religious city,” he said in Hathras.

DGS stands by removal of curbs on Indian ships

These vessels are LPG carrier *BW Loyalty*, container ships *CMA CGM Manaus* and *CMA CGM Diamond*, and *Volvox* dredger.

While removing restrictions, the DGS has asked Masters of vessels operating in or transiting through the Gulf region, including the Strait of Hormuz and adjoining waters, to maintain heightened security vigilance, closely monitoring navigational warnings and other warnings or instructions received from security agencies. Indian-flagged vessels have been advised to coordinate with the United Kingdom Marine Trade Operations and Maritime Information Cooperation Centre and keep the Indian Navy, missions in respective countries, as well as the DGS updated on transit.

Calling the DGS notification a mature one, Anil Devli, CEO of Indian National Shipowners Association, said every shipowner would be vigilant and would only proceed after doing a total risk assessment.

IMO Secretary-General Arsenio Dominguez, said that shipowners had to make their own risk assessment before transiting either of the two routes currently available.

Elephant death puts focus on ‘killing zone’

The study estimated that 744 wild elephants died between April 2019 and March 2025 and human-induced causes accounted for 77 deaths while Munnar and Ranni areas accounted for “higher incidence of electrocution.” The primary elephant mortality zones in the State also included the Wayanad landscape, Nilambur region and Periyar-Ranni-Konni landscape.

The death of a pregnant wild elephant in the Silent Valley forest in 2020, also a suspected case of the animal getting injured after feeding on fruit stuffed with firecrackers, had stirred widespread outrage. The animal, which was unable to eat after suffering injuries to its mouth, had stayed in a river in an apparent effort to ease pain.

The Forest Department has been asked to probe the latest incident, said Shibu Baby John, State Forest Minister.

Ironically, the incident occurred just a day after senior forest officials met at Thattekad to discuss the “Management Effectiveness Evaluation (MEE) for elephant reserves for the 2026-27 cycle.”

The post-mortem report indicated the cause of death as septicæmia caused by injuries. The factors that led to the incident are being looked into, said P. Pugazhendi, Chief Wildlife Warden, Kerala.

CJP stir: Wangchuk goes on fast at Jantar Mantar

The activist starts strike calling for Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation; says he cannot remain silent when young people raised concerns over the education system; AISA joins hunger strike

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Environmentalist and educator Sonam Wangchuk began a hunger strike on Sunday afternoon at the Jantar Mantar here, where the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) has been protesting since June 20, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for multiple irregularities in the examination system.

Prior to the hunger strike, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke had said on social media platform X that he had visited Rajghat with Mr. Wangchuk to pay tribute to Mahatma Gandhi. Soon after that, Mr. Wangchuk began his hunger strike, seeking justice for students and calling for the Minister’s resignation.

‘Water cut off’

The Delhi Police had cut off the water and sanitation facilities at Jantar Mantar after Mr. Wangchuk announced his strike, Mr. Dipke alleged.

The police termed the allegation “falsehoods and misinformation”. The Deputy Commissioner of Pol-



Activist Sonam Wangchuk having a word with CJP founder Abhijit Dipke at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Sunday, demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

ice, New Delhi said online that the Delhi Police, being a law enforcement agency, had no role to play in providing these facilities.

Explaining his decision to join the protest, Mr. Wangchuk said education had been close to his heart for the last 40 years and that he could not remain silent when young people raised concerns over the education system.

“I have been forced to sit here, I am not doing this happily. I am sitting on a fast in support of both issues. Many people ask me, you were doing a move-

ment in Ladakh, why are you with CJP now. Education, which is the issue here, has been close to my heart for the last 40 years, since I was a student,” he said. Many others, including farm leaders, joined the protest on Sunday. At least six student activists have joined Mr. Wangchuk in the hunger strike, demanding Mr. Pradhan’s resignation.

“I am not alone. I have been told that some youth are also going on hunger strike. Wherever you are, I salute you,” he said. The All India Students’ Associa-

tion (AISA), which previously expressed solidarity with the CJP’s protest, on Sunday said six students associated with the AISA have decided to go on the hunger strike, too.

“Students have called for the strike in complete solidarity with the call by Sonam Wangchuk, and will fight shoulder to shoulder in the struggle for Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation, repeal of NEP (National Education Policy) 2020, and scrapping of the National Testing Agency,” the AISA said in a statement. (With PTI inputs)

Ram Temple graft case concerns assets of a ‘juristic person’

NEWS ANALYSIS

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



The embezzlement case is based on the alleged misappropriation of devotees’ donations at the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya. ANI

The Ram Temple embezzlement case raises serious allegations of misappropriation of cash and valuables donated by devotees as an “expression of piety” to a Hindu deity, uniquely considered a ‘juristic person’ who is a minor in law.

Series of judicial decisions, right from the days of the Privy Council to Supreme Court’s judgments in the Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple and the Ramjanmabhoomi Temple cases, hold the deity as a legal entity capable of holding property.

The Padmanabhaswamy Temple case saw the Supreme Court hold that donations given by wor-

shippers belong strictly to the deity. By detailing Maharaja Marthanda Varma’s act of dedication of his kingdom to the deity, the 2020 judgment provided an insight into the acceptance of the deity as a separate entity as far back as in the 18th century.

The importance of the act of donating to a deity as

an expression of Hindu piety was discussed by the Privy Council in *Vidya Varuthi Thirtha Swamigal v. Balusami Ayyar and Others*, a case law which dates back to 1921. “Hindu piety finds expression in gifts to idols and images consecrated and installed in temples,” the judgment said.

It noted that these gifts

or donations by devotees were made to the deities *eo nomine* (in the name of the deity itself), providing proof that a deity was a juristic entity vested with the capacity of receiving gifts and holding property.

The courts have, however, recognised that a dedicated property vests in the idol only in an “ideal sense”. The physical possession and management of that property must be taken over by a “human agency”. But this person or group of individuals have the status of a mere ‘manager’. The ownership of a dedicated property vests entirely with the deity.

This legal principle was reinforced by Justice B. K. Mukherjea in his lead judgment in *Angurbala Mullick versus Debabrata Mullick* in 1951. “In a Hindu religious endowment, the en-

Indian diplomats hold talks with officials of Chinese news agency

Press Trust of India
BEIJING



Shweta Singh with Wang Jianxin at Xinhua News Agency, in Beijing, China. PTI

Officials of the Indian Embassy in Beijing have met representatives of China’s state-run Xinhua news agency amid ongoing efforts between the two countries to normalise relations.

The meeting took place between Shweta Singh, Minister of the Embassy, and Wang Jianxin, Deputy Director-General of the Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation Department of Xinhua.

“On 24 June 2026, Embassy officials met representatives of Xinhua News Agency at its headquarters in Beijing and exchanged views on issues of mutual interest,” the Indian Embassy said in a post on X, along with a photo on Sunday, without providing details.

Enhancing engagement

Indian officials described the meeting as part of efforts to enhance engagement with Chinese media.

Both countries are currently in the process of normalising relations post the Eastern Ladakh conflict in 2020, which had frozen their ties.

Currently, both countries have resumed Kailash-Manasarovar Yatra, vi-

sas and flights. China, for its part, has been calling for restoration of visas for its journalists.

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, in his meeting with National Security Adviser Ajit Doval last week in New Delhi, called for both countries to promote exchanges in various fields, including media.

Mr. Wang was in New Delhi to attend the BRICS NSA meeting.

In April 2023, China froze the visas of two Beijing-based Indian journalists while they were on leave in India, alleging that Chinese scribes were not receiving visas.

Later, Beijing also declined to renew the visa for one more Indian journalist while permitting the PTI bureau to continue.

Recently, China has given a journalist visa to *The Hindu* Correspondent to work from Beijing.

After 15 years, over 250 CRPF officers get maiden promotion

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

More than 250 officers of the country’s largest paramilitary Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) finally received their first career promotion after a wait of 15 years, officials said on Sunday.

Their much-delayed elevation came about after prolonged litigation and conditional resolution of pending service issues related to seniority and vacancies.

On June 26, the CRPF headquarters issued orders promoting 263 Assistant Commandant-rank (AC) officers to Deputy Commandant (DC). The AC rank is the entry-level officer post in the Central forces.

“The development is significant because it will act as a morale booster for the officers who waited 14 to 15 years for their first

promotion, which should ideally have come in five years,” a senior CRPF officer said.

SC order

A Supreme Court order issued on April 16 clarified the position in this context.

The CRPF headquarters followed up with the Union Home Ministry, leading to the issuance of the much-delayed order, the officer said.

He said the newly promoted officers would, however, continue to serve in their current positions because their posting orders could not be issued immediately due to “operational and administrative constraints”.

A second officer said these orders would further impact lower-rank personnel, as promotions to the AC rank would now occur from the Inspector rank, creating a ripple effect for other subordinate ranks.

Indian Army contingent to participate in Seychelles’ 50th National Day event

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



The contingent of 32 personnel from the Assam Regiment is led by Captain Aryan H. Deolekar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

An Indian Army marching contingent will participate in the 50th National Day celebrations of the Seychelles on Monday, marking the golden jubilee of the island nation’s Independence.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will attend the event as the guest of honour, underscoring the close bilateral ties between the two countries.

The Army said the contingent of 32 personnel from the Assam Regiment will be led by Captain Aryan H. Deolekar.

An Indian Navy marching contingent, accompanied by a military band, will take part in the ceremonial parade, reflecting the strong and enduring defence partnership between India and the Seychelles.

The two nations share long-standing historical ties that have grown into a robust strategic partnership spanning defence cooperation, development assistance, maritime security, culture, and trade, it added.

The participation of Indian armed forces personnel in the celebrations is seen as a symbol of mutual trust, military camaraderie, and the shared commitment of both countries

to deepen bilateral relations. Such ceremonial engagements also reinforce defence cooperation and highlight India’s role as a reliable partner in promoting peace and security in the Indian Ocean region.

Officials said India’s participation in the Seychelles’ golden jubilee celebrations reaffirmed the special partnership between the two countries and reflected the expanding scope of bilateral engagement.

Justice P.S. Narasimha to be part of SC Collegium

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Justice P.S. Narasimha is set to become a member of the Supreme Court Collegium following Justice J.K. Maheshwari’s retirement on Sunday.

Being the fifth senior-most judge, Justice Narasimha will officially be a part of the Collegium until he retires on May 2, 2028.

The Collegium will now comprise Chief Justice Surya Kant, Justice Vikram Nath, Justice B. V. Nagarathna, Justice M. M. Sundresh, and Justice P. S. Narasimha.

Under the Collegium system, which came into existence in 1993 following a Supreme Court judgment, the five top judges of the apex court recommend the appointment, transfer, and elevation of judges to the Supreme Court and the 25 High Courts.

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Defections part of larger conspiracy; rebel MPs must be disqualified: Uddhav

A portrait of a middle-aged man with dark hair and glasses, wearing a yellow traditional Chinese shirt. He is seated and looking towards the camera with a slight smile. The background features a floral patterned wall.

Congress kicks off units' revamp with new appointments



VB-G RAM G will push workers to starvation: Congress

A portrait of a man with white hair and glasses, wearing a dark blue jacket, speaking into a microphone. He is identified as the author of the book 'The Indian Economy: Growth, Inequality and the Role of the State'.

Govt. launches portal for auditing of rural schemes

Humayun Kabir booked for making 'threatening remarks'

CM
YK

CM
YK

A CH-CHE

*Med cover
inadequate
and not
affordable*

You should be sure that you can maintain an even higher medical fund and that should be over and above your retirement planning

How much hospitalisation insurance is enough? For the average city living middle class family ₹5 lakh looks woefully inadequate because which city hospital even has ₹5,000 rooms?

Because, with the sub limit of 1% of sum insured (SI) on room rent, you will be dipping into your pocket for the extra room rent. You can buy an additional cover for extra premium to protect against that. Be sure to read up about it and opt for it on your next renewal. But what is left uncovered is the share of expenses you will bear on all other services like surgeons' or physicians' fees going by the sub-limit rules. Mercifully medications and diagnostic procedures don't come under the sub-limit. A higher SI comes at a higher premium and that escalation is going to be endless, we have seen. The real problem we are left to focus on is the inadequacy of SI. With rising healthcare costs, the question has changed to how much of your expenses are left uncovered by your SI. Remember, that gap is going to widen each coming year. This diminution of protection is cause for serious concern.

Let's get back to the 'Why not self-insure for the first ₹10 lakh and take only a top-up?' idea.

We saw that if you can maintain a ₹10 lakh medical fund and keep enhancing it, if you can resist spending it on that family holiday, and if you can pay your hospital expenses and replenish your fund without feeling the financial pain, this is a workable idea. This comes with some age-related pros and cons. For the below-30s family, it may work well because hospitalisations may be few and far between and the fund can keep earning returns and growing. However, nobody can predict serious illnesses and accidents and the fund would be one more demand on the family's expenses.

In the next decade and a half of your life, till age 45, the medical fund is much easier to create and maintain with better earnings and cashflows, and you can have no basic policy, saving on premium and maintain the top up. However, this is when lifestyle illnesses start making their appearance, parents are getting older and children can contribute with illnesses and spills. At this stage you can move to start a small basic policy of ₹5 lakh

From age 45 to 60 avoiding a basic policy means substantial premium savings as the rates rise sharply. If you have significant accumulated wealth you can rely on self-insurance with maybe that small basic policy we saw earlier plus a sizeable top up.

This is the age group when chronic illnesses increase and hospitalisation can be expected. You should be sure that you can maintain an even higher medical fund and that should be over and above your retirement planning. Insurance becomes a much more efficient part of the game plan at this stage. Your medical fund also should be periodically reviewed and enhanced, preferably during your earning years when the funds are still flowing. By the 60s your basic policy should be for a higher SI and that means you should enhance it a few years prior in order to work off the waiting period for pre-existing diseases. Definitely do this before retirement so that you are not left without insurance. Getting a fresh policy or enhancement of SI after this age is quite a challenge. If your employer provides a retirement policy, it is wise to opt for that and build other policies around it.

Much as we may plan about and spend on insurance, we are truly happy When we don't need to use it. So, after reading all this if you plan on jogging every morning, cutting back on smoking and junk food and getting a full night's sleep, even better!

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



People pleasing: Money leaves the wallet not out of necessity, but out of social expectation and peer pressure. SAINATH B.

Treatflation: The invisible 'ghost' in office culture

This ghost does not ask for a feast; neither does it care if it's month-end or your budget is already stretched; it simply asks for a bite, again and again, which may gobble up your savings over time

Vaishali R. Venkat

There is a hungry 'ghost' 'haunting' your office. It neither rattles chains, bangs on doors, roams dark corridors, nor lives in deserted, dilapidated buildings. It silently lurks in WhatsApp groups, emails or phone calls. Its ambush is never a one-time affair. It strikes again and again, often when least expected.

This invisible ghost rarely asks for a feast and never compels; a small bite usually suffices. It does not care whether you are carrying a mountain of debt, whether it's month-end, budget is already stretched, or if your wallet can withstand another hit. Most employees feed this ghost: a pocket-friendly contribution for a birthday cake, a party for promotion, a wedding or a team lunch. The strangest thing is that this ghost never feeds on fear but on goodwill. Nobody is forced to offer a bite, yet, this ghost is somehow fed. I call this ghost Treatflation, a portmanteau of 'treat' and 'inflation' that captures the rising cost of recurring workplace celebrations.

It is the accumulation of countless small contributions in the name of treats. Each request seems modest in isolation. Yet, over time, these small acts of participation can quietly become a drain on personal finances. It's an invisible financial burden whe-

It is our tendency to change our behaviour in order to fit in with a group and maintain good relationships with the people around us

rein workplace camaraderie slowly begins to resemble a subscription fee for a 'utility' you never subscribed to.

Treatflation is not created by greedy bosses or demanding colleagues. It is sustained by decent people doing decent things. Every contribution is usually voluntary; every occasion is genuine; every amount is modest. Yet, over the course of a career when thousands of such gestures accumulate, they raise an uncomfortable question: can even good will become so expensive?

Treatflation is powered by a force that social psychologists call 'Normative social influence.' It is our tendency to change our behaviour in order to fit in with a group and maintain good relationships with the people around us.

Put simply, it is the urge to conform to group expectations. Most employees do not contribute because they are forced by their bosses or colleagues, but because they want to fit in and maintain good relationships and avoid being the only person who declines. As a result, money leaves the wallet not out of necessity, but out of social expectation and peer pressure.

Most employees contribute because they want to fit in, maintain good relationships and avoid being the only person who declines

sure. In the 1950s psychologist Solomon Asch demonstrated this tendency in a series of conformity experiments. He found that people often aligned their behaviour with a group even when their own judgement suggested otherwise. The lesson was simple: the desire to fit in and avoid standing out proved stronger. This behaviour underlines Treafalton is a simple human need: the desire to belong. Most people would rather contribute a few hundred bucks than risk appearing indifferent to the group.

The consequences of this desire are not merely social; they are financial as well. Left unchecked, this desire expresses itself through a steady stream of small contributions.

What makes Treatfalcon's compensation different from most is not its size, but its frequency. A ₹500 crore distribution rarely attracts attention, but if it occurs just twice a month, it adds up to ₹12,000 a year. Over a 30-year career, the cumulative cost can exceed ₹36 lakh. The result is a financial leak that many employees may feel the pinch of, but rarely plug. Viewed differently, the same

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.00	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.55
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.80	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.35	6.50	7.35	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65

Home Loan Interest Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.30	6.80	6.70	6.75
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.70	6.10	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.80	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.65	6.20	6.10	6.00

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(in %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.25	7.20-9.15	7.20-9.15
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
ICICI Bank	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.47-11.70	7.47-11.70	7.47-11.70

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(in %)			
Federal Bank	8.35 - 10.25	7.35 - 10.25	7.35 - 9.25
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #
Tata Capital	8.00 #	8.00 #	8.00 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	9.25 #	9.25 #	9.25 #
Sammaan Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #
*Extra 0.05% rate concession to borrowers taking Insurance Rates as on July 24 #Onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

What are asset allocation funds

Asset allocation, the proportion of how much you should invest in various asset classes to create a portfolio, is the first step in your investment process

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Asset management companies in India can now offer lifecycle funds, a category of funds introduced by SEBI this year. Such funds can hold equity, bonds and commodities. Hybrid funds typically carry equity and bonds.

For our discussion, we refer to all multi-asset-class funds as asset allocation funds. In this article, we discuss the characteristics of such funds and what you should be mindful of before investing in such funds. Asset allocation funds typically have an asset allocation range. Suppose a fund invests in equity and bonds and has an asset allocation range of 65-75% in equity and 25-35% in bonds. This allows fund managers to tactically move between 65% minimum allocation to equity to a maximum allocation of 75%.

Now, asset allocation, the proportion of how much you should invest in various asset classes to create a portfolio, is the first step in your investment process. Importantly, your asset allocation is a function of how important your life goal is. Your children's education portfolio, for instance, may require a conservative allocation (more bonds, less equity) than, say, your retirement portfolio.

By investing in asset allocation funds, you are giving up the first step in your investment process. This is because fund managers will manage the asset allocation based on the fund's mandate and their view of the asset markets, not based on your life goals. This is not to say that asset allocation funds do not serve a purpose. It is useful if you believe that determining asset allocation for each of your goal is a tedious process. Technically, outsourcing your asset allocation would mean hiring an investment advisor to custom-tailor portfolios to meet your life goals. Asset allocation funds cannot fulfill such objectives.

Asset allocation funds carry some benefits. For one, such funds are tax efficient compared to you separately managing an equity and a bond portfolio for each goal. This is because fund managers moving money between stocks and bonds within the fund will not be taxable for you, unless you sell your units in the fund. For another, you get the benefit of professional expertise. Fund managers are better equipped than us to understand how to tactically move between equity and bonds. But if you prefer bank deposits for your bond allocation, asset allocation funds may not be an optimal fit for your goal-based investment.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

14 nationals killed in helicopter crash in Saudi Arabia: state media



Ousted leader Sheikh Hasina vows to return to Bangladesh 'this year'



Israel approves landmark proposal to recognise Armenian genocide



Skydiving plane crash in eastern France kills all 11 people aboard



Iran attacks Bahrain and Kuwait after U.S. strikes, threatens to halt talks

Israel strikes south Lebanon despite framework accord

Europe suffers over 1,300 excess deaths amid heatwave crisis

Two killed, major oil refinery damaged in Russia as Ukraine keeps up assault

Iraqi officials held in anti-corruption drive; raids in Green Zone

Sport

Rohit unleashes massive throw, qualifies for Asiad

Russell back to winning ways

A CH-CHE

WIN-WIN SITUATION

Austria and Algeria advance after playing out a thrilling draw



REUTERS

Austria and Algeria played out a thrilling 3-3 draw in Kansas City on Saturday in what amounted to a win-win result in their World Cup Group J finale. It allowed both to progress to the round of 32 while eliminating Iran from the tournament. Iran would have advanced as one of the eight best third-placed teams had Austria or Algeria won.

AGEING LIKE FINE WINE

Modric becomes oldest assist provider at the marquee event



REUTERS

Veteran midfielder Luka Modric continues to defy age. At 40 years and 291 days, Croatia captain Modric became the oldest player on record — since 1966 — to register an assist at a World Cup. He delivered the decisive corner that Nikola Vlasic headed home in the 83rd minute to seal the Group L victory over Ghana.

BONUS POINT

India exacts revenge on England in penalty shootout in Pro League



WORLDSPORTPICS

India beat England 3-2 in a penalty shootout after a goalless draw in the return leg of the Hockey Pro League in London on Sunday. Abhishek, Shilanand Lakra and Hardik Singh converted in the shootout as India secured the bonus point with a composed display. Zachary Wallace and David Goodfield scored for England.

ON THE CHARGE

Rachin and Mitchell shine as New Zealand eyes series victory



AFF

England captain Ben Stokes' prospects of a victorious farewell were slim as New Zealand closed in on a series win in Nottingham. England was 103 for four at stumps on day four. **The scores:** New Zealand 438 & 234/8 decl. in 83 overs (Rachin 94, Mitchell 100 n.o., Archer 4/53) vs England 354 & 103/4 in 15 overs (Foulkes 3/42).

Messi magic again as Argentina stays perfect with easy victory

Coming off the bench, the 39-year-old scores from a free-kick in the reigning World champion's 3-1 win over Jordan; Lo Celso and Lautaro also get on the scoresheet; Scaloni's men finish the first round with nine points

FIFA WORLD CUP

Avon Sengupta
DALLAS

The hallmark of champions is not simply their brilliance but the quality waiting beyond the spotlight. Argentina started without several of its biggest names, including captain Lionel Messi, against Jordan yet scarcely looked diminished as it completed a flawless Group J campaign with a 3-1 triumph on Sunday.

Lionel Scaloni made nine changes to the side that beat Austria, with only goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez and striker Lautaro Martinez retaining their spots. For much of the opening half, the loudest cheers inside the Dallas colosseum were reserved not for the players on the pitch but the man sitting in the dugout.

Every time the giant screen showed Messi, seated alongside clubmate Rodrigo De Paul with an amused expression, the stadium erupted before returning to its familiar chorus. On the field, Argentina's understudies gave their fans more to cheer for. The breakthrough arrived in the 19th minute after Mohannad Abutaha brought Giovanni Lo Celso down just outside the penalty box. The midfielder punished the untidy Jordanians by curling his free-kick around a poorly or-



Air of invincibility: Messi capped off another good Argentine performance with a second-half strike. AFP

The standings

GROUP J	M	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Points
Argentina (Q)	3	3	0	0	8	1	7	9
Austria (Q)	3	1	1	1	6	6	0	4
Algeria (Q)	3	1	1	1	5	7	-2	4
Jordan (E)	3	0	0	3	3	8	-5	0

Q: Qualified | E: Eliminated

Source: FIFA

ganised wall.

Argentina's pressure soon brought another reward. Lautaro's angled effort struck the post before Marcos Senesi, following up on the rebound, was caught in the face by Nizar

Al-Rashdan's raised boot. After a VAR review, the referee pointed to the spot, and Lautaro calmly sent his penalty into the bottom-left corner.

In Messi's absence, Argentina found different

routes to goal, and around the half-hour mark, the contest was already drifting away from Jordan. But the Asian side refused to become a supporting act. Mousa Al-Tamari's sliding finish in the 55th minute cut short the deficit, just as Messi started warming up.

The moment the No. 10 stepped towards the half-way line, the crowd found another gear. The roar that greeted his arrival dwarfed every celebration that had come earlier. His now-customary World Cup goal — for a seventh successive match — arrived in the 80th minute as he outfoxed Jordanian goalkeeper Yazid Abulaila with a low free-kick that flew past the wall. At last, the full house of 70,649 got what it had been waiting for.

Round of 32 schedule

DATE	TEAMS	TIME
June 29	South Africa vs. Canada	00.30 a.m.
June 29	Brazil vs. Japan	10.30 p.m.
June 30	Germany vs. Paraguay	2 a.m.
June 30	Netherlands vs. Morocco	6.30 a.m.
June 30	Ivory Coast vs. Norway	10.30 p.m.
July 1	France vs. Sweden	2.30 a.m.
July 1	Mexico vs. Ecuador	6.30 a.m.
July 1	England vs. DR Congo	9.30 p.m.
July 2	Belgium vs. Senegal	1.30 a.m.
July 2	USA vs. Bosnia & Herzegovina	5.30 a.m.
July 3	Spain vs. Austria	00.30 a.m.
July 3	Portugal vs. Croatia	4.30 a.m.
July 3	Switzerland vs. Algeria	8.30 a.m.
July 3	Australia vs. Egypt	11.30 p.m.
July 4	Argentina vs. Cape Verde	3.30 a.m.
July 4	Colombia vs. Ghana	7 a.m.

* The dates and times pertain to India

THE RESULTS

Group L: Croatia 2 (Susic 31, Vlasic 83) bt Ghana 1 (Luckassen 73); Panama 0 lost to England 2 (Bellingham 62, Kane 67). **Group K:** DR Congo 3 (Wissa 68-pen, 90+1, Mayele 78) bt Uzbekistan 1 (Shomurodov 10); Colombia 0 drew with Portugal 0. **Group J:** Jordan 1 (Tamari 55) lost to Argentina 3 (Lo Celso 19, Martinez 31-pen, Messi 80); Algeria 3 (Belghali 45, Mahrez 60, 90+3) drew with Austria 3 (Arnautovic 28, Sabitzer 55, Kalajdzic 90+6).

Tuesday's matches

ROUND OF 32

Germany vs. Paraguay, 2 a.m.
Netherlands vs. Morocco, 6.30 a.m.
Ivory Coast vs. Norway, 10.30 p.m.

The day and time(s) pertain to India

Japan out to douse Brazil's firepower

Avon Sengupta
HOUSTON

The World Cup has always belonged to the dreamers. The knockout rounds, however, have little time for romance.

For Japan, that moment arrives in Houston on Monday. The Samurai Blue have become one of world football's most consistent overachievers. Since 2002, on four occasions, it has emerged from difficult groups, but Japan is yet to win a men's World Cup knockout match.

Standing in its way, this time, is Brazil — a nation that has lifted the trophy more times than any other.

Carlo Ancelotti's side appears to be finding its rhythm since falling behind early on Matchday 1, before drawing with Morocco. Brazil responded with six unanswered goals in wins over Haiti and Scotland to finish top of its group and Neymar's return after 981 days has added another boost to its attack.



Suzuki will have a tough job on his hands. AFP

Recent history, though, offers a note of caution, as Brazil lost 3-2 to Japan in a friendly in October 2025. Japan coach Hajime Moriyasu is trying to draw inspiration from that result.

"Last time we proved to Brazil that we aren't a pushover," Moriyasu said. "That is great progress for us. The Brazilian team is a top team in the world and we greatly respect them. In

The standings

GROUP L	M	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Points
England (Q)	3	2	1	0	6	2	4	7
Croatia (Q)	3	2	0	1	5	5	0	6
Ghana (Q)	3	1	1	1	2	2	0	4
Panama (E)	3	0	0	3	0	4	-4	0

Q: Qualified | E: Eliminated

Source: FIFA

The standings

GROUP K	M	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Points
Colombia (Q)	3	2	1	0	4	1	3	7
Portugal (Q)	3	1	2	0	6	1	5	5
DR Congo (Q)	3	1	1	1	4	3	1	4
Uzbekistan (E)	3	0	0	3	2	11	-9	0

Q: Qualified | E: Eliminated

Source: FIFA

the match, we don't know what will happen. We will have a chance to win as well."

Japan, meanwhile, is on an unbeaten 10-match run. It reached the round of 32 after defeating Tunisia 4-0 and drawing with the Netherlands and Sweden, with Daichi Kamada (3) and Ayase Ueda (2) leading the goal-scoring charts.

Brazil, however, pos-

sesses a different level of firepower. Vinicius Junior has four goals, Matheus Cunha has scored three and teenager Rayan has emerged as another exciting option in Ancelotti's evolving attack.

Japan has spent decades proving it belongs among football's elite. On Monday, it must prove it can finally beat one of them when it matters.

Ireland stuns India, clinches T20I series



Top show: Ireland's superlative effort ended India's 16 T20I-series winning streak. GETTY IMAGES

Press Trust of India
BELFAST

Jai Moondra, a software engineer from Rajasthan's Tonk, rocked a star-studded batting line-up filled with IPL stars as Ireland did the unthinkable, shocking reigning T20 World champions India by one run to complete a historic 2-0 series win here on Sunday.

In slightly nippy, blustery conditions, Moondra (3/32), who still holds an Indian passport, removed Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma for first-ball ducks with icing on the cake being skipper Shreyas Iyer's wicket.

India managed only 153 for nine after the hosts made 154 for eight. Towards the end, Harshit Rana (21, 10b, 2x4, 1x6) tried his best before being dismissed off the penultimate delivery of the contest.

The series defeat also ended India's 16 T20I series winning streak that started mid-2023. Earlier, debutant Prince Yadav gave a good account

SCOREBOARD

IRELAND

Tim Tector c Abhishek b Harshit 5 (6b, 1x4), Ross Adair c Tilak b Arshdeep 16 (7b, 1x4, 2x6), Harry Tector c Kishan b Prince 53 (47b, 5x4, 1x6), Lorcan Tucker c Kishan b Prince 15 (18b, 2x4), Ben Calitz c Tilak b Dube 37 (23b, 3x4, 2x6), Gareth Delany b Dube 0 (1b), George Dockrell c Axar b Arshdeep 19 (14b, 1x4, 1x6), Liam McCarthy c Kishan b Prince 2 (4b), Jai Moondra (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (lb-2, nb-1, w-3); 6; Total (for eight wkts. in 20 overs): 154.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-17 (Tim, 1.5 overs), 2-21 (Adair, 2.2), 3-48 (Tucker, 7.3), 4-113 (Calitz, 14.4), 5-113 (Delany, 14.5), 6-144 (Dockrell, 18.3), 7-153 (Harry, 19.4), 8-154 (McCarthy, 19.6).

INDIA BOWLING
Arshdeep 4-0-35-2, Harshit 3-0-17-1, Prince 4-0-22-3, Dube 3-0-25-2, Shedge 2-0-25-0, Axar 4-0-28-0.

INDIA
Sanju Samson lbw b Moondra 0 (1b), Abhishek Sharma c Holland b Moondra 0 (1b), Ishan Kishan

1x4), Beth Mooney c Radha b Deepti 22 (20b, 2x4), Phoebe Litchfield c Smriti b Shree Charani 24 (25b, 2x4, 1x6), Ellyse Perry c Shafali b Shree Charani 56 (38b, 8x4), Ashleigh Gardner (not out) 53 (29b, 3x4, 3x6), Georgia Wareham (not out) 4 (2b, 1x4); Extras (lb-3, nb-2, w-4); 9; Total (for four wkts. in 19 overs): 172.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-4 (Voll, 0.2), 2-54 (Litchfield, 6.6), 3-68 (Mooney, 9.1), 4-168 (Perry, 18.4).

INDIA BOWLING
Renuka 4-0-41-1, Kranti 1-0-12-0, Shafali 4-0-29-0, Shree Charani 4-0-32-2, Deepti 4-0-31-1, Radha 2-0-24-0.

Toss: India.
PoM: Perry.
Australia won by six wickets with one over to spare.

possibly didn't hear the call for a quick run. Jemimah and Harmanpreet put on 64 for the third wicket before the former was retired out to bring in India's designated finisher Richa Ghosh. But, on this day, the captain took over that role.

Harmanpreet swung her bat to maximum effect. She hit her counterpart for three sixes in the final over, which went for 23 runs.

But, Perry and Gardner put the smile back on their captain's face.

of himself with three scalps. Harry Tector (53) and Ben Calitz (37) added 65 runs for the fourth wick-

et before Dube (2/25) got wickets off successive deliveries to help restrict the hosts.

INBRIEF



Jangoo and Chase put WI in command against Sri Lanka

A double-century by relative newcomer Amir Jangoo, *in pic*, and 194 from captain Roston Chase put the West Indies in a commanding position with the sixth-wicket pair's partnership of 401 lifting the home side to a mammoth first innings total of 626 for nine declared on the third day of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Antigua on Saturday.

The scores: Sri Lanka 308 in 71.5 overs & 15/1 in 4 overs vs West Indies 626/9 decl. in 160.5 overs (Jangoo 233, Chase 194, Milan Rathnayaka 5/124).

Padikkal scores half-century as match ends in a draw

Devdutt Padikkal hit a patient 67 (101b, 5x4) in India-A's second innings as the opening "Test" against Sri Lanka-A ended in a draw with weather disrupting the proceedings on the fourth and final day at Galle on Sunday. The second "Test" will be played from July 2 to 5.

The scores: India-A 452/6 decl. & 189/8 decl. in 57 overs (Devdutt Padikka 67, Dilum Sudeera 5/49) drew with Sri Lanka-A 330 & 70/2 in 15 overs.



Stokes to retire from int'l cricket after NZ Test series

England captain Ben Stokes will retire from international cricket after the third Test against New Zealand, the team said on Sunday. The announcement came midway through day four of the Test at Trent Bridge. It ends Stokes' 15-year international career that peaked when he starred for England in its win over New Zealand in the 50-over World Cup final in 2019.

India finishes third in AVC Men's Volleyball Cup

India finished third in the AVC Men's Volleyball Cup after defeating Bahrain 25-23, 23-25, 25-21, 25-17 in the playoff match in Ahmedabad on Sunday. Skipper Jeromin Vinith scored 24 points while Joel Benjamin and Chirag Yadav logged 17 points apiece. In the title decider, Indonesia got the better of South Korea 34-32, 25-16, 25-23.

Bhagat claims gold; Krishna wins mixed silver

Para badminton star Pramod Bhagat won the men's singles SL3 gold at the British & Irish International, in Dublin on Sunday. In an all-Indian final, Bhagat defeated compatriot Nitesh Kumar 23-21, 21-14. Bhagat also added a bronze in the mixed doubles SL3-SU5 category alongside Manisha Ramdass. Tokyo Paralympic champion Krishna Nagar won silver in the mixed doubles SH6 category alongside Nithya Sre, while adding a bronze in the men's doubles SH6 event with Sivarajan Solaimalai and also singles.

Haryana men and Punjab women emerge champions

Haryana and Punjab emerged the men's and women's champions of the fifth Fast5 senior National netball championship at the Vaasavi International School in Puducherry on Sunday. Puducherry Chief Minister N. Rangasamy graced the occasion as the chief guest.

The top-three: Men: 1. Haryana, 2. Puducherry, 3. Punjab & Telangana; **Women:** 1. Punjab, 2. Haryana, 3. Puducherry & Telangana. **Special awards: Best players: Men:** Shahrukh Khan (Puducherry), Tarun (Haryana); **Women:** Versha, Sonakshi (both Haryana), Angel, Jaswinder (both Punjab), Jaya Priya (Puducherry).

LIVE TELECAST

Zimbabwe vs Bangladesh: One-off Test, Day 2, FanCode, 1 p.m.

England vs New Zealand: Third Test, Day 5, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.

Wimbledon: Star Sports 1, 2, SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 3.30 p.m. onwards

FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 10.30 p.m. & 2 a.m. (Tuesday)

Sinner starts clear favourite to defend his crown

The top-seeded Italian will have to contend with the hot weather; Sabalenka will look to end a Slam drought as she targets a maiden crown at SW19; Djokovic against begins quest for 25th Major

WIMBLEDON

Reuters
LONDON

Wimbledon begins on Monday, with defending champion Jannik Sinner chasing a fifth Grand Slam title and women's top seed Aryna Sabalenka chasing her first Major of the year.

In the absence of rival and two-time winner Carlos Alcaraz, Sinner is the clear favourite this year, but the Italian may have to contend with the hot weather and his own lack of preparation. After his second-round defeat at the French Open from a near-winning position when he cramped up in sizzling conditions, the 24-year-old skipped the warm-up tournaments ahead of the grasscourt Slam.

He said this could work to his benefit, however, ahead of his opening clash with Serbian Miomir Kecmanovic on Monday.

"If you play a tournament before here, maybe it's not going the way you would like to, you come here with some doubts," he told reporters. "If you don't play any tournament, you don't have these doubts, you just go and play."

Sabalenka has been at the top of the WTA rankings since late 2024, but the Belarusian has only won one Grand Slam title in the past 18 months, despite reaching four finals. She also suffered a collapse



Boon, not a bane: Sinner is unperturbed by his lack of preparation ahead of the tournament and says it could work to his benefit. REUTERS

against Diana Shnaider in the French Open quarterfinals last month, losing the last 10 games in a row.

She said she wanted to "quit tennis" after her collapse in the French Open but has since worked with a psychologist and said she was not affected as much by losing to Jessica Pegula in this month's Berlin Open semifinals.

"I felt really good throughout the tournament here. I struggled a little bit here and there, (but) overall I feel like things are clicking back together," she told reporters ahead of her opening match against Teodora Kostovic.

The four-time Major champion has never won Wimbledon, but she has reached the semifinals in her last three appearances.

Novak Djokovic has spent the last 2-1/2 years trying to capture a 25th Major that would see him overtake Margaret Court.

Since he won his seventh Wimbledon title in 2022, the Serb has reached two finals and a semifinal at the All England Club.

"Playing on grass, comparing to clay, you don't need to exert as much physical effort. So that's better for me," he added.

"I always loved playing on grass. I have a very good score here, history, in Wimbledon. That gives me a higher dose of confidence coming into the tournament."

Serena Williams, another seven-time champion, had doubts about accepting a wildcard into this

year's singles draw but is now looking forward to enjoying her return.

"I think in general my expectations are definitely different for the first time in my career," Serena told reporters on Sunday in London. "I feel like my feelings are just – not that I never enjoyed it before, or else I wouldn't be here today – but I feel like I'm really going to enjoy being out there."

Monday's order of play:

Centre Court: 1-Sinner vs. Kecmanovic (Srb); 1-Sabalenka vs. Kostovic; Wu vs. 7-Djokovic (Srb).

Court No. 1: Ruzic vs. 30-Raducanu; Cilic vs. 8-Medvedev; Linette vs. 5-Andreva.

Court No. 2: 4-Pegula vs. Vidmanova; Zheng vs. 26-Norrie; 3-Auger-Aliassime vs. Shevchenko; Korpatsch vs. 7-Gauff.

Ethan, Harshavardhan become India's 96th and 97th GMs

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

India got its 96th and 97th Grandmasters in a day as Ethan Vaz and G.B. Harshavardhan completed the achieved their respective titles at different tournaments on Saturday.

The 14-year-old Ethan from Goa, obtained his third and final GM norm at the "Chess Summer in Sarajevo - GM Mix" tournament in Sarajevo, Bosnia & Herzegovina. He also won the GM tournament with a score of seven points from nine rounds while remaining unbeaten.

Harshavardhan became the country's 97th GM by remaining unbeaten in the second Chola Chess GM-norm round-robin tournament in Chennai on Saturday.

The 22-year-old from Chennai finished with four



Ethan and Harshavardhan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

wins and five draws for 6.5 points from nine rounds.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Harshavardhan said: "It's a huge relief and I am so happy. I got both my IM title in 2020 and my GM crown in Chennai. That is a great coincidence."

He added that the win over Michal Krasenkow in the seventh round was crucial as the Polish GM was leading till then.

"Krasenkow was unbeaten and the win was very important for me.

"My Elo rating is 2507 and I want to take it to 2600 by the end of the

year," he said.

Harshavardhan earned his first GM norm by winning the Asian Juniors in 2022, and his second came at the Asian Continental in 2025, through which he qualified for the FIDE World Cup in Goa.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA I division league, fourth round, day one, Sea Hawks vs. Young Stars (Tagore); Globe Trotters vs. SKM (Vivekananda); Grand Slam vs. Vijay (CSK-Guru Nanak); Jolly Rovers vs. Singam Puli (IITM-Chemplast); Nelson vs. Pristine (Wahe Guru-A); Swaraj vs. MRC-A (A.M. Jain), 9.30 a.m.

AROUND THE CITY

Krasenkow and Aleksandrov triumph

GM Michal Krasenkow of Poland and GM Aleksej Aleksandrov of Belarus emerged champions of the Second Chola Chess GM Norm Round Robin Tournament and the First Chola Chess IM Norm Round Robin Tournament, respectively.

Krasenkow scored seven points from nine rounds to clinch the GM Norm title, finishing ahead of IM G.B. Harshavardhan (6.5) and IM Harsh Suresh (6).

In the IM Norm event, Aleksandrov finished with 6.5 points, edged FM Daakshin Arun (6), who earned his second IM norm, while IM L.M.S.T. De Silva (5.5) took third place.

Rakshan and Aravind slam centuries

M. Rakshan (124, 108b, 10x4, 2x6) and B. Aravind (103, 97b, 12x4) helped

If I were India coach, I will build the batting line-up around Sooryavanshi: Swann

CRICKET

S. Shrivathsan

If there is a competition to find Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's biggest fan, former England off-spinner Graeme Swann will certainly be in the mix.

During a 40-minute media interaction on Sunday, Swann could not stop waxing eloquent about the 15-year-old, even when questions pertaining to other topics were posed at him. Describing Sooryavanshi as a "once in a generation talent", the 47-year-old felt that a "box-office batter" like him should not be kept away from the India T20I XI for long.

"If I were the Indian captain or coach, I would have Sooryavanshi in immediately. The sooner India plays him, the sooner he gets exposed to international cricket.

"There is no reason why he cannot be the best player in the world for the next 15 years. He is that good," Swann said.

The southpaw has been made to wait for his international debut after being benched in the two-match series in Ireland.

"If you look at the XI, there is none who deserves to be dropped based on performances.

"But you could argue that Sooryavanshi outperformed them all in the IPL. Let us face it; his stats do not lie. So personally, I would build a batting lineup around him.

"The hype around him is real. He can hit the best



Sooryavanshi. SLIC

bowlers all over the park and destroy them. He is not old enough to drive in this country (England) but is old enough to smash the best bowlers.

"He can be an absolute match-winner. When you look at the Indian T20I and ODI teams, they are full of world-class players. The fact that a kid who is more exciting has come along is astonishing," Swann went on to add.

The Englishman also opined that new skipper Shreyas Iyer will match the high standards set by his predecessors Rohit Sharma and Suryakumar Yadav.

(*Watch India vs. England first T20I live on July 1 from 10 p.m. IST on Sony Sports Ten 1 SD & HD, Sony Sports Ten 5 SD & HD & Sony MAX.*)

Srikanth makes it to US Open final

Press Trust of India
FULLERTON

K. Srikanth edged out Japan's Yudai Okimoto in a three-game thriller to progress to the men's singles final of the US Open Super 300 badminton championships here.

Srikanth recorded a 22-20, 15-21, 21-19 win over World No. 33 Okimoto in 72 minutes to enter his first final of the season where he will meet World No 46 Su Li Yang of Taiwan.

In women's singles, sixth seed Devika Sihag fell to Denmark's second seed Line Christophersen 21-15, 11-21, 15-21 in the semifinals.

The results (semifinals): Men: K. Srikanth bt Yudai Okimoto 22-20, 15-21, 21-19; Su Li Yang bt Rounak Chouhan 17-21, 19-21.

Women: Line Christophersen bt Devika Sihag 15-21, 21-11, 21-15.

Rieko bags the Chief Minister's Cup

BENGALURU: Mr. P. Arun Kumar's Rieko (Neeraj up) won the Chief Minister's Cup (1,200m), the chief event of the races held here on Sunday (June 28). The winner is trained by S. John.

1. LITTLEOVER PLATE (1,200M): PREVIEW (Suraj) 1, Calix (Akshay K) 2, Sai Princess (Jagadeesh) 3 and Charming Prospect (A. Ashbar) 4. 2. 1-1/2 and Snk. Im 12.68s. Rs. 35 (w), 10, 11 and 49 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 105, FP: 68, Q: 22, Trinella: 917/872, Exacta: 5,067/1,303. Favourite: Calix.

Owner: Sans Craintes Stud Farm (Faizan Khan) 3 and Magna Carta (S. Sachin) 4. 4-1/4, 1/2 and 3. Im 39.79s. Rs. 17 (w), 12, 13 and 51 (p), SHP: 33, THP: 115, FP: 70, Q: 49, Trinella: 1,013/634, Exacta: 1,217/347. Favourite: Michiko.

Beauty (Ankush) 4. Not run: Lots Of Luck. 4-3/4, 5-1/4 and 6-1/2. Im 24.54s. Rs. 16 (w), 10, 14 and 11 (p), SHP: 40, THP: 29, FP: 73, Q: 44, Trinella: 93/34, Exacta: 492/453. Favourite: Steely Challenge.

Owners: M/s. Rapar Galloping Stars LLP & Mr. Rajan Aggarwal. Trainer: Darius Byramji.

4. CHIEF MINISTER'S CUP (1,200M): REIKO (Neeraj) 1, Dream Seller (Sandesh) 2, Crown Drive (Hindu S) 3 and Knotty Charming (Antony) 4. 3/4, Lnk and Hd. Im 11.21s. Rs. 22 (w), 10 and 13 (p), SHP: 27, THP: 33, FP: 41, Q: 18, Trinella: 136/83, Exacta: 357/60. Favourite: Dream Seller.

Owner: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. Trainer: S. John.

5. KARNATAKA SUB-AREA CUP (1,400M): VEGATA (Antony) 1, Lux Aeterna (Akshay K) 2, Victoria Doreasani (L.A. Rozario) 3 and Irish Coffee (Aru) 4. Not run: Gachchhatu. 3/4, 3-1/4 and 2. Im 23.65s. Rs. 16 (w), 10, 12 and 12 (p), SHP: 34, THP: 27, FP: 61, Q: 47, Trinella: 183/56, Exacta: 840/784. Favourite: Vegata.

Owners: M/s. Cherie Sports Pvt Ltd rep. by Mrs. Smita Bajoria &

Mr. Cheriyan Abraham. Trainer: P.S. Chouhan.

6. TUDOR JET PLATE (1,200M): RIVER DEEP (A. Asbar) 1, Carat Love (Akshay K) 2, Noble Cause (S. Sachin) 3 and IL Volo (Kiran Rai) 4. 1-1/2, 1-1/2 and Nose. Im 12.98s. Rs. 23 (w), 11, 13 and 15 (p), SHP: 37, THP: 49, FP: 70, Q: 34, Trinella: 157/72, Exacta: 233/93. Favourite: River Deep.

Owner: Mr. Md. Minhaj Raza. Trainer: V. Lokanath.

7. DESERT GOD PLATE (1,600M): IMPERADOR (Vishal Bunde) 1, Regal Aristocracy (Antony) 2, Pledge (Akshay K) 3 and Absolute Thunder (Aru) 4. 1-1/4, 1-1/4 and 5-3/4. Im 37.09s. Rs. 61 (w), 15, 14 and 15 (p), SHP: 43, THP: 49, FP: 330, Q: 103, Trinella: 539/103, Exacta: 1,101/688. Favourite: Pledge.

Owners: M/s. Arun Alagappan Racing LLP, Mr. M.P. Vikram, Mr. A.S. Karthik Chandra, Mr. Ronak J Kimmane & Mr. Ananth Iyengar. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar. Jackpot: Rs. 1,177. Runner up: 70. Mini Jackpot: 667. Treble (i): 84; (ii): 246.

N. Sudarshan

If you are looking for the most complete CVs in world tennis, you shouldn't be going beyond Serena Williams and Novak Djokovic. Serena has 23 singles Majors – an Open Era record – and 14 in doubles. She has won every Slam at least thrice in singles and twice in doubles.

The American has clinched the Olympics singles gold once (London 2012), the doubles gold thrice (Sydney 2000, Beijing 2008 and London 2012), and the erstwhile Fed Cup (now Billie Jean King Cup) in 1999. Since 1990, no player has won more singles titles on the WTA Tour than Serena's 73.

Djokovic has an all-time men's record 24 singles Majors, secured every Slam at least thrice, and bagged all nine Masters 1000s and ATP Finals at least twice. He won the Davis Cup for Serbia in 2010, and when he pocketed the Olympics singles gold at Paris 2024, following a sensational victory over Carlos Alcaraz, it filled the last existing gap.

It is natural for everyone to expect that the two legends will now be resting on their incredible laurels, vacationing year-round, soaking in the sunshine, swimming the sea, and taking long and calming strolls with their partners and children in tow.

Back to the grind

But from Monday at Wimbledon, Serena and Djokovic will be seen hitting tennis balls again, not for fun but in all seriousness as full-blooded professionals. The former is closing in on 45, and is a mother of two, with the second child yet to turn three. The latter has just stepped into the 40th year of his life and is also a father of two.

Yet, here they are, sparring with players a decade or two younger, and looking to shoe-horn another high-impact bullet point into their already exceptional resumes.

Serena, a seven-time winner and four-time runner-up at Wimbledon, is making a comeback to competitive singles for the first time since US Open 2022 while Djokovic, a seven-time winner and three-time finalist at SW19, will be on his 21st successive visit to the All England Club.

What is their motivation? Serena, in her own words, has said that it is an opportunity to show her two daughters what it takes to perform on the biggest stage. She has also been inspired by her sister Venus, 46, who made the doubles quarterfinal at the 2025 US Open. In fact, Serena and Venus will also be playing doubles at Wimbledon, having been granted a wild card.

"I had nothing better to do," Serena said at the Queen's Club in London recently, eliciting great laughter from the crowd which watched her pair up with Canada's Victoria Mboko and win a round. "I got tired of sitting at home. My kids are out of school for the summer, so why not?"

"I don't need to win. I've won more than most people have in their whole lives. I don't have anything to lose. Everything is a gain," she observed.

For Djokovic, it is the "thrill of competition". At the Australian Open earlier this year, he beat the then World No. 2 Jannik Sinner over five sets in the semifinal, and pushed No. 1 Alcaraz hard in the final before succumbing in four sets. A month later at Indian Wells, he stated that he would keep going as long as he has the "flair and quality, and the motivation".

"I still enjoy getting out there in front of the fans and being competitive," Djokovic said. "I have proven to myself primarily, and to others, that I can still compete at the highest level. I still have that edge, and I'll keep on going as long as I feel like it."

Serena certainly looks leaner and fitter than when she last played on the Tour, thanks to the effectiveness of new-age weight-loss drugs. After her second pregnancy, she couldn't "beat the weight" and turned towards GLP-1 medication.

Glucagon-Like Peptide 1 (GLP-1) is a naturally occurring hormone that nudges the pancreas to release insulin, slow down digestion and reduce hunger. Semaglutides and Tirzepatides perform this function when ingested in the form of medicines, reducing food intake and leading to significant weight loss.

These two drugs have been on the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) monitoring programme since 2024 and there is a raging debate whether they can be bracketed as performance-enhancers. How Serena benefits will further this discussion.

But this is only one part of the story. Playing tennis is part of Serena's muscle memory and that aspect is not going away. At her peak, she had the most devastating serve on Tour, and even a watered-down version will give her the first-mover advantage on a slick and fast surface like grass.

There is also her on-court aura, the overarching nature of which can make opponents shrink. Only a handful have risen to the challenge, like Naomi Osaka and Bianca Andreescu did when they beat Serena in their maiden Major finals at the 2018 and 2019 US Opens respectively.

"I see her in the gym more than I have



GETTY IMAGES

seen her when she was at her prime," Djokovic said last week at Wimbledon. "It's admirable, honestly, the effort she's putting in. For her to come back after years of being absent, two children later, and to give so much effort not just for her own satisfaction but to also give all of us the pleasure of seeing her is remarkable."

However, there are challenges galore. A similar comeback in singles was once attempted by Martina Navratilova in 2002 when she was nearly 46. That lasted only 10 matches over three years, and featured just three wins. Navratilova did go on to have a wonderful second wind in doubles, but Serena has said that anything other than singles is "not my journey right now".

Lacking the edge

Having not experienced a competitive environment for nearly four years, Serena is bound to be rusty. Even before that, she was in a state of semi-retirement, playing just eight singles matches from Wimbledon 2021 and tasting defeat in five.

Present-day singles is also more powerful and explosive than at any other time. A reality check may well await Serena, who once dominated the Tour with her athleticism and superior heft of stroke.

Unseeded and unranked as she is, the early rounds will not be easy. Against World No. 87 Maya Joint, Serena may have a softer-than-expected opening, but she is drawn to meet the fast-rising 21-year-old from Philippines Alexandra Eala, the big-serving Czech and 2021 finalist Karolina Pliskova, and defending champion Iga Swiatek in the subsequent rounds.

In contrast, Djokovic, by virtue of still being in the top-10, has the ranking protection to ease in. Unfortunately, the seventh seed has also been dealt with a banana skin of a draw.

After China's Wu Yibing (No. 102), the Serb can potentially meet Stefanos Tsitsipas, a two-time Slam finalist and former World No. 3 but now down to 87, Joao Fonseca, who beat him in the third round at French Open and is now No. 27, and 12th seed Andrey Rublev in the second, third and fourth rounds

respectively. Since the run to the final in Melbourne, Djokovic has done precious little, playing just seven matches and losing three. After winning the ATP Finals in November 2023, which came two months after he secured the last of his 24 Majors, he has just two Tour titles – ATP 250s in Geneva and Athens, both last year.

In fairness, Djokovic's struggle has not been in beating mid-level players but the elite ones in Sinner and Alcaraz. As they are almost always ranked in the top-two, every player who dreams of a Slam invariably has to beat both.

Prior to the success over Sinner at the Australian Open, Djokovic had lost five straight times to the Italian, with three of those at Majors. Against Alcaraz, he has lost four of his last five Slam contests, with three of them coming in finals.

While there is little doubt that the duo has elevated the quality of tennis, the physicality in the game has gone through the roof. So much so that Djokovic, who once raised fitness standards to such levels that it triggered massive shifts in the way Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal prepared, is now struggling to keep up. It doesn't help that Sinner and Alcaraz are nearly 15 years younger.

Playing catch-up

"It's just age, the wear and tear of the body," Djokovic said after losing to Sinner in the semifinal at Wimbledon 2025. "As much as I'm taking care of it, reality hits me. It's tough for me to accept that because I feel that when I'm fresh and fit, I can still play really good tennis. I have proved that."

"But playing best-of-five [sets] has been a real struggle physically. The longer the tournament goes, the worse the condition gets. These guys are fit, young and sharp. I feel like I'm going into the match with a tank half-empty. It's just not possible to win a match like that."

"But it's one of these things I accept and embrace, deal with the reality the way it is, and try to make the most out of it."

Wimbledon 2026 will give Djokovic the best opportunity to do this. In Alcaraz's absence, he has just one big worry in Sinner. Alexander Zverev is the second

seed, but the reigning French Open champion has a history of stumbling on grass and never gone past the fourth round at The Championships.

Though Djokovic's best surface was hard for long, the lush green lawns of south-west London have been immensely hospitable. Over the years, he has mastered the art of moving on the slippery turf, improved his volleying to a significant degree, and spot-serves like the best in the business.

Remarkable record

In his last seven visits to Wimbledon, he has earned four titles, made two appearances in the final and one in the semifinal. The dash to the 2024 summit clash, in particular, was astounding, because it hadn't even been six weeks since Djokovic had gone under a surgeon's scalpel to mend a torn meniscus in his right knee.

"I think I'm better prepared than I was for Roland-Garros," Djokovic said looking ahead. "Obviously, playing on grass, compared to clay, you don't need to exert as much physical effort. And I always loved playing on grass. I have a very good history at Wimbledon."

"Roland-Garros was physically very draining, demanding, but the effort was there. Anyway, I was planning to peak at Wimbledon after the shoulder injury kept me away from the Tour. I knew that going straight into Roland-Garros was going to be quite difficult... maybe too big a challenge for me, and that's what happened."

"But I knew that's going to give me a bit more time to prepare for Wimbledon. So, hopefully, I'll have a good tournament here."

With a combined 47 Grand Slam singles trophies, Serena and Djokovic are tennis royalty. Can they be at their regal best at the crown jewel of the sport?

THE GIST

Serena is returning to the Tour so that her daughters can watch her play as a professional. Her sister Venus' comeback last year has also proved inspirational

Djokovic continues to play for the "thrill of competition", and also because he still believes he can beat the top players. The most recent example came at the 2026 Australian Open when he defeated Sinner in the semifinal

Serena's record at Wimbledon and her playing style which flows from the serve can be her allies. But a severe lack of match practice and opponents' power game can be her foes

Djokovic has a proud record at SW19 and has developed a fine grass-court game. But having played just seven matches since the final in Melbourne, he may be undercooked

Djokovic has an all-time men's record 24 singles Majors, secured every Slam at least thrice, and bagged all nine Masters 1000s and ATP Finals at least twice



Serena has 23 singles Majors – an Open Era record – and 14 in doubles. She has won every Slam at least thrice in singles and twice in doubles

Smart AI caching can keep the data flowing when disaster strikes

In cooperative caching, different parts of a disaster-response network, including satellites, drones, base stations, and emergency vehicles, work together to store and share useful data; when one node receives or generates important content, such as satellite images or video, nearby nodes may also cache copies based on demand

Shamim Haque Mondal

Two years ago, Mundakkai and Churalmala in Kerala experienced powerful landslides that killed hundreds of people. Last year, a large village in Dharali, Uttarakhand, was washed away following heavy rain. In the monsoon season of 2025, the States in Northeast India were devastated by frequent floods. More than a hundred people lost their lives after heavy rain in Uttar Pradesh on May 13-14 this year.

During such disasters, it is common for telecom towers to topple over, power lines to be cut, and roads to be closed. In these situations, real-time information as to what is happening on the ground, where people are stuck, which routes are still open, etc. becomes crucial for rescue workers and medical workers. In the absence of such communication, rescue operations are delayed, more property is damaged, and more lives are lost.

Cooperative caching
'Solving' communications in disaster-affected areas is a long-standing problem. Recently, in a paper published in the *IEEE Transactions on Services Computing*, researchers from Ireland, led by Sangita Dhara of Trinity College Dublin, presented a novel approach – a way to transmit important real-time information using a technology called collaborative caching even if the local network is in a subpar condition.

At a time of disaster, the local administration typically has three main communication channels: satellite or satellite-based communications, drones or unmanned aerial vehicles, and some *ad hoc* network based on the ground. A satellite can beam data down over a wide area, so accessing that signal is relatively easy, but the big problem here is data latency, i.e. the delay in getting information. Time is of the essence. It is also possible to take pictures from the sky or transmit live video using drones. However, they are limited by their short range, limited battery capacity, and, above all, obstacles in the form of inclement weather. Finally, ground-based wireless networks can help with local communication – but they are often damaged or non-functional during disasters.

In this context, the researchers have presented cooperative caching. Here, different parts of a disaster-response network, including satellites, drones, base stations, and emergency vehicles, work together to store and share useful data. When one node receives or generates important content, such as satellite images or video, nearby nodes may also cache copies based on the demand. This cooperation allows rescue teams to



During disasters, real-time information about where people need help and which routes are still open is crucial for rescue and medical workers. REUTERS

retrieve information from the nearest available source rather than a distant origin, reducing delay, improving reliability when infrastructure is damaged, and increasing the chance that critical information is available in real time.

Automatic decision-making
Creating this caching system is technologically not simple, however. The drones are airborne, rescue vehicles are on the road, and the position of satellites is constantly changing. It is also difficult to know when and where information will be required, plus the storage of each device will be limited.

To address this problem, the researchers developed a statistical model called contextual multi-armed bandit (CMAB), an AI model that optimises caching decisions quickly.

The model learns from each of the previous decisions, then reviews three factors: what data are recently available, what data demand is currently high, and how much memory is needed in the cache.

For example, it would be helpful to understand that a photo taken 10 minutes before a flood is more effective than a photo taken one hour before the flood. Similarly, video footage or a map of a place that most rescuers are asking for is more important than those that fewer ones are looking for. Sometimes, instead of caching high-resolution video – such as 4K video – short text alerts or warning messages could help rescuers remain

The researchers developed a statistical model called contextual multi-armed bandit, an AI model that optimised caching decisions quickly

productive without taking up large amounts of storage. The model is taught to make such decisions automatically.

Federated learning
While in CMAB each node learns from what information it alone has, a more advanced version called FMAB – short for federated multi-armed bandit – learns from its information as well as what the nodes nearby have learnt.

“Caching decisions are executed periodically rather than per request, amortising the computational cost,” the researchers wrote in their paper. “Even the highest observed decision latency of Contextual MAB [around 87 microseconds] remains negligible compared to network delays, ensuring system complexity does not hinder the practical applicability for dynamic and real-time, post-disaster deployments.”

The work also highlights the importance of a three-tier network, where space, air, and ground are working together, called Space Air Ground Integrated Network (SAGIN). Here, each layer plays a unique role, but the limitations that exist between them are greatly reduced due to caching, and the system becomes more efficient. In the

post-disaster scenario, it is important not to look at all the information that is available but only at which information is more useful. An updated road map can tell us which bridges are still usable while a live video can let us know that boats are urgently needed in a specific part of the floodplain.

All together
As a result, content should be seen not only as data but as time-dependent actionable data. And the goal of advanced caching should be to learn how to store the most valuable information in the most appropriate place with limited resources.

To meet this goal, SAGIN works to build external infrastructure, CMAB helps to make acceptable decisions, and FMAB can make the network stronger in the post-disaster period by spreading those decisions across multiple nodes.

However, the results of this simulation-based study depend on many parameters, such as the weather at the time, the flight of the drone, energy management, hardware malfunctions, cyber security, and the behaviour of rescuers in reality.

Moreover, it is not always technically possible to determine which content is valuable or preferable. In many cases, the needs of the local administration or humanitarian considerations can also speed up the rescue.

(Shamim Haque Mondal is with the Physics Division, State Forensic Science Laboratory, Kolkata. shamimmondal709@gmail.com)

THE GIST

It is common for communication to get disrupted when a disaster occurs. The absence of real-time information delays rescue operations

Researchers from Ireland found a way to transmit important real-time information using a technology called collaborative caching even if the local network is in a subpar condition

The work also highlights the importance of a three-tier network, where space, air, and ground are working together, called Space Air Ground Integrated Network (SAGIN)

BIG SHOT



Zoraide de Deus Mota, 104, Zulina de Deus Nunes, 103, and Levita de Deus Nunes, 109, pose for a photo after samples were collected for longevity research in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil on June 23. Recently named the world's oldest living siblings, the sisters are part of a study exploring genetic factors linked to longevity. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT? Life on Mars: enduring mystery

Vasudevan Mukunth

In a new study in *Science Advances*, an international team of researchers has reported finding organic matter on Mars. Using the NASA Perseverance rover, the team recorded a distribution of complex organic carbon within an ancient river valley on the red planet's Jezero Crater.

Using the rover's SHERLOC instrument, the researchers detected a complex and hardy form of organic matter called macromolecular carbon within fine-grained mudstones. According to the study paper, published in *Science Advances*, this is significant as it represents the most robust detection of organic material in Jezero Crater to date and is the first time such a material has been found directly on a natural rock surface on Mars.

Over the last decade, the NASA Curiosity rover has found organic molecules in Gale Crater, proving the building blocks of life could be preserved in Mars's lakebed rocks. However, Perseverance's previous scans of the floor of Jezero Crater only showed localised and faint hints of organic materials.

The new evidence, from the Neretva Vallis channel, suggests organic matter could be more widespread on Mars than thought. The fact that these organic materials have also been found alongside minerals like carbonates and



A selfie taken by NASA's Perseverance Mars rover in 2025 shows the Cheyava Falls rock to the rover's left. NASA

sulphates suggests they may have been trapped and preserved by water-driven processes billions of years ago. While the new study noted that these organics could have been formed by geological (i.e. abiotic) processes rather than biological ones, the findings are, in the paper's words, “astrobiologically compelling”, showing that complex carbon can survive the planet's harsh radiation for aeons.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of children covered in T.N. polio vaccine programme

53 in lakh. Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay launched a Statewide health drive, aiming to administer the oral pulse polio vaccine to children under the age of five. The National Pulse Polio Immunisation campaign was rolled out across more than 43,000 authorised vaccination centres. PTI

Govt. schools covered in Rajasthan's mental health programme

1,500 Officials claimed that Rajasthan is the first State in the country to launch such a programme. RSCERT Director Shweta Fagediya said that a pilot project conducted in Sirohi and Banswara districts in 2024 yielded encouraging results. PTI

Approximate surplus stock held by private firms for kharif season

30 in per cent. FSII Chairman Ajai Rana said while the sector was well-prepared following a bumper seed production season for corn, rice, and millets, a survey of 1,000 farmers showed 75% had already purchased seed while the remaining 25% were waiting for the monsoon. PTI

Number of targets in Iran struck by the U.S. army during ceasefire

10 The U.S. military said on Saturday it had struck 10 targets in Iran at President Donald Trump's direction, continuing a string of attacks that have shaken the war's uneasy ceasefire. The U.S. says strikes were a response to an Iranian attack on an oil tanker. PTI

Magnitude of the earthquake in northeastern Japan

6.1 A magnitude-6.1 earthquake rattled northeastern Japan early on Sunday, according to the Japan Meteorological Agency. No tsunami warning was issued, and there were no immediate reports of damage or casualties. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Can neutral ships be lawfully attacked?

What protections does international law afford neutral merchant vessels? When can neutral ships lawfully lose that protection? Can oil tankers and blockade runners be treated as military targets? What legal remedies are available to India after the deaths of its seafarers? How does international law regulate attacks?

LETTER & SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh

The story so far:

Recently, the U.S. Navy carried out Hellfire missile strikes against three merchant tankers – *Marivex*, *Settebello* and *Jaiveer* – all carrying Indian seafarers. While *Marivex* and *Jaiveer* escaped without casualties, three Indians aboard *Settebello* – the chief engineer, an engine fitter, and a deck cadet – were killed. Although U.S. President Donald Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian signed an MoU on June 17, intended to end the conflict and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, this fragile peace has already been breached by fresh confrontations between U.S. and Iranian forces. Beyond these shifting geopolitical tides, the fundamental legal questions surrounding the attacks on neutral shipping and the accountability for civilian lives lost in these combat zones remain unresolved.

What laws govern naval operations during armed conflict?

The two primary bodies of law governing naval operations during an international armed conflict are the (1) “law of naval warfare” – a branch of law of armed conflict or International Humanitarian Law (IHL) – and the (2) “law of the sea”. The former regulates the conduct of hostilities at sea, including which vessels may be attacked and when merchant ships may be visited and searched, captured, destroyed after capture, or attacked, as well as the declaration and enforcement of ‘naval blockades’. The latter provides the maritime legal framework within which the rights and obligations of belligerent (warring states) and neutral parties operate, thereby shaping the geography of naval operations.

The “law of the sea”, set out primarily in the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), often called the “Constitution of the Oceans”, defines maritime zones such as the territorial sea (up to 12 nautical miles), exclusive economic zones (EEZs) (up to 200 nautical miles), the high seas, and international straits. Although the U.S., Israel, Iran, and some neutral states are not parties to UNCLOS, its relevant provisions are widely regarded as customary international law binding on all states.

Are neutral merchant vessels and civilians protected?

The “law of naval warfare” does not confer unrestricted authority upon belligerents. Its operation is constrained by IHL, neutrality law, and the “law of the sea”. While ethical restraints on warfare have roots in ancient Greek, Roman, Indian, and Chinese civilisations, their modern legal expression lies in IHL, codified in the 1949 Geneva Conventions and supplemented by other treaties and customary international law. Designed to limit human suffering by regulating the ‘means’ and ‘methods’ of warfare, IHL protects the wounded, sick, prisoners of war, civilians and civilian objects, while restricting certain weapons and methods of combat. Unlike the UN Charter, which governs the legality of starting a war (*jus ad bellum*), IHL regulates the conduct of war (*jus in bello*) through the principles of ‘distinction’, ‘proportionality’, ‘military necessity’ and ‘precaution’.

In naval warfare, as on land, civilians and civilian objects are generally protected from attack. Accordingly, submarine cables, pipelines, container ships, and tankers carrying food,



Commercial vessel *MT Jaiveer* after it was attacked off the coast of Oman near Shinas Port. ANI

fertilizer, or oil may not be targeted. Likewise, the right of “transit passage” through international straits, codified in Part III, Section 2 (Articles 37-44) of UNCLOS and recognised under customary international law, also continues during armed conflict. Equally important is the law of maritime neutrality – a key component of the “law of naval warfare” – which regulates relations between belligerent and neutral states by protecting neutral territory, shipping and commerce from unnecessary interference while requiring neutrals not to provide military assistance to either side. In the Strait of Hormuz, which straddles the territorial seas of Iran and Oman and carries roughly one-fifth of global oil supplies, neutral merchant vessels therefore remain entitled to exercise “transit passage” despite the hostilities.

When do the neutrals lose their protected status?

Under IHL, during an armed conflict, attacks may be directed only against ‘military objectives’. At sea, some vessels (like enemy warships and naval auxiliaries) qualify as ‘military objectives’ by their nature, while others acquire that status because of their use or activities at the time of attack. Yet, the “law of naval warfare” permits attacks on merchant vessels in certain limited circumstances, although not in neutral waters. The San Remo Manual on International Law Applicable to Armed Conflicts at Sea (1994) – the most influential restatement of the “law of naval warfare” – provides that objects may be targeted when they make an effective contribution to military action and their total or partial destruction, capture, or neutralisation offers a definite military advantage (Paragraph 40 of the Manual).

Applying this principle to neutral shipping, Paragraph 67 of the Manual, which specifically addresses merchant vessels flying a neutral state’s flag, permits attacks on neutral merchant ships reasonably believed to be carrying “contraband” or breaching a “blockade”, and after prior warning they intentionally and clearly refuse to stop, or intentionally and clearly resist visit, search or capture, or where ships ‘otherwise make an effective contribution to enemy’s military action’. The International Law Association’s Helsinki Principles on the Law of Maritime Neutrality (1998) adopt a similar approach. By contrast with

‘neutral’ merchant vessels, which typically cannot be captured merely for trading with the enemy, ‘enemy’ merchant vessels are generally liable to “capture” outside neutral waters. However, even the ‘enemy’ merchant vessels may be attacked only when, and for as long as, they qualify as ‘military objectives’, for instance, by laying naval mines, performing functions normally undertaken by naval auxiliaries, or gathering and transmitting tactical intelligence.

Can oil tankers be attacked?

Significantly, the U.S. military has alleged that the Palau-flagged *Settebello* was illegally transporting Iranian oil. While disputed, the claim raises the question of whether oil carried aboard a ‘neutral’ merchant vessel can be treated as “contraband”. Given its military utility, oil may, in certain circumstances, qualify as “contraband”, but only if destined for enemy-controlled territory or otherwise supporting the enemy’s military effort – a concept particularly relevant to neutral merchant vessels, since enemy merchant ships are already generally liable to capture outside neutral waters.

More fundamentally, the legality of attacking oil tankers turns on whether they qualify as ‘military objectives’. Under the traditional view, commercial exports do not become military objectives merely because they generate revenue for a belligerent; the tanker and its cargo must make an effective contribution to military action, and their destruction must offer a definite military advantage. Ordinary export trade, including oil sold on the open market, is generally considered too remote from military operations to meet this test. In contrast, the U.S.-backed “war-sustaining” theory treats objects that finance or sustain an enemy’s war effort as military objectives, potentially rendering oil exports that generate revenue closely linked to military operations lawful targets.

What about naval blockades?

The U.S. justifies the strikes on the grounds that the vessels were violating an American blockade. Both the San Remo Manual and the Helsinki Principles recognise “blockade” enforcement as a legitimate belligerent right and permit force against neutral vessels reasonably believed to be breaching a lawful “blockade”. A blockade seeks to prevent vessels and aircraft of all nations from

entering or leaving enemy-controlled ports, airports or coastal areas, thereby restricting both the import of supplies and the export of goods. Notably, it must be publicly declared, applied impartially to all vessels of all states, including neutrals, and be effective rather than a mere “paper blockade”.

However, compliance with the aforesaid “law of naval” warfare governing blockades is not, by itself, sufficient to justify attacks on neutral vessels. As many international law scholars argue, such actions must also comply with the UN Charter, adopted in 1945, following the devastation of World War II, to maintain international peace and security. Article 2(4) of the Charter prohibits states from using force against another State’s ‘territorial integrity’ or ‘political independence’, except pursuant to UN Security Council authorisation or in self-defence under Article 51, including, under the contested but widely invoked doctrine of ‘anticipatory’ self-defence, against an imminent threat.

Since the U.S. war against Iran arguably has neither Security Council authorisation nor a valid self-defence claim, many scholars view it as violating the UN Charter itself. Consequently, the “blockade” forms part of an unlawful use of force and is therefore unlawful as a matter of *jus ad bellum*, regardless of its compliance with the law of naval warfare (*jus in bello*). In other words, the “blockade” and measures taken to enforce it may satisfy the latter but not the former, since the exercise of belligerent rights to enforce a “blockade”, unlike self-defence or UN Security Council authorisation, is not recognised as an exception to Article 2(4)’s prohibition on the use of force.

Importantly, the UN Security Council may authorise forcible measures by member states, and Article 42 expressly identifies “blockade” as one such measure. However, outside a “blockade” authorised by the Security Council, there does not seem to be any *jus ad bellum* basis for using force against neutral merchant vessels to enforce a “blockade”. The exercise of belligerent rights through attacks on vessels flagged to “neutral” states, including the forcible enforcement of a “blockade” against neutral shipping, sits in direct tension with the UN Charter, irrespective of whether force may lawfully be used against the blockaded state itself. Even where a state possesses a valid *jus ad bellum* basis for using force to repel an armed attack, it may employ only such force as is necessary and proportionate; that right does not ordinarily extend to attacks on third states or their vessels absent an independent basis for self-defence.

What is next for India?

Beyond the serious doubts surrounding the legality of the U.S. strikes, key questions remain: what intelligence supported the attack; were less intrusive measures such as boarding, diversion or capture available; and were adequate warnings issued to allow civilians to protect themselves? For India, the incident is not merely a diplomatic issue but a legally cognisable injury to its nationals. Under the doctrine of “diplomatic protection”, India has standing to espouse claims arising from injuries to its citizens caused by an internationally wrongful act, demand explanations, seek accountability and compensation, and call for an independent investigation into the deaths of the three seafarers. (*Kartikey Singh, lawyer, and currently working as a Law Clerk-cum-Research Associate at the Supreme Court of India. The views expressed are personal*)

THE GIST

International law generally protects neutral merchant vessels and civilians during armed conflict, but that protection may be lost in limited circumstances, such as when ships effectively contribute to military action or breach a lawful blockade.

The legality of the U.S. strikes on neutral tankers depends not only on the law of naval warfare but also on the UN Charter, raising questions over the lawfulness of the blockade, the targeting of neutral shipping, and compliance with international humanitarian law.

The deaths of three Indian seafarers raise issues of state responsibility, diplomatic protection, accountability, and India’s right to seek explanations, an independent investigation, and compensation.

